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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra)

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Part 9 of Any Version of Reality

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Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

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It's dangerous to go alone

by catrasredemption (dimensionhoppingrose)

Summary

-YouTuber/Gamer AU-

Catra and Adora dated. Past tense. But people are crazy , and Catra walked away from it - and Adora.

A video game convention five years later brings them back together, and brings some old problems to the surface.

-OR-

The exes because fans are crazy AU that no one actually needs

Notes

No, this is definitely NOT commentary on fandom mentality or how toxic people can be. Why would you ask?

This was supposed to be a one-shot, but what can you do?

See the end of the work for more notes

Prologue

"One-twenty blindfolded is still being routed," Entrapta said. She was sprawled across Catra's bed, playing on her laptop and watching Catra tap mindlessly on her controller. "The seventy-star record holder hasn't even managed it yet."

"So?" Catra asked without looking away from her screen. "Record holders aren't the only ones who can do things. Maybe I'll get there first and usurp the crown."

"Not impossible," Entrapta agreed. "Maybe a little unlikely, but your viewers certainly think you're capable of it."

Catra finally paused her game, turning to look at Entrapta, raising an eyebrow. "Did you hack into my account?"

"Not really. It's not hacking if you use the same password for everything and I happen to know it. You should really change that."

"Noted. Are you having fun with my analytics page?"

"A blast! Your comments are overall very positive. I *do* agree with the ones who say you should get cat-ear headphones, though."

"No." Catra turned back to her game, un-pausing it. She had one headphone cup over her ear, listening to the bump and bonk sounds Mario made every time she bounced him off a wall. She would've had both on, but it wouldn't stop Entrapta from talking, so she figured she'd listen to the nerd.

"How far have you gotten, anyway?"

"I can get up to eighty before I start getting lost." It was frustrating. She could play the game beginning to end without blinking, but the second she added a blindfold, everything got complicated. She wasn't quite up to the standards of the world record holder, but she

was in a solid second place and had been for awhile. "Eighty-one if I try really hard."

"That's not bad. Have you watched the record holder?"

"Yeah, he livestreams on Twitch a lot. He's up to eighty-five, but some of the routing is kind of convoluted to me."

They heard the vague sound of the downstairs door opening, and Scorpia calling, "We brought dinner!"

Catra looked at Entrapta. "Probably from the vegan place, right?"

"Almost definitely."

They went back to their respective screens, Entrapta acting as Catra's sort of social media expert (she wasn't allowed to post anything, but she was great at tracking trends), and Catra running through Tiny-Small World for the eighth time that day.

"You've almost worked your way back up to pre-hiatus numbers," Entrapta commented after a few minutes of nothing but cheery music and *woo-hoo!*s filling the silence. "You could make a major comeback if you figured out a decent blindfolded one-twenty route."

"I don't *want* to make a major comeback," Catra muttered, sinking down in her seat. "I just want to play games and make money."

"Well, you're doing that as well. Your Patreon numbers are impressive."

"It's covering the rent."

"And it'll definitely go over the top if you make a comeback."

Catra groaned, rolling her eyes. She knew Entrapta didn't really care about those kinds of things—she was just interested in the numbers around it. She knew Catra had been popular at one point, and watching her ascent back into the video game hall of fame was

probably fascinating. She'd taken the first place on the leaderboard for Super Mario 64 one-twenty glitchless months ago, and everyone had lost their minds when they'd seen her name back on the leaderboard. It had been a good time to restart her Patreon, she had decided. Thankfully , her old tutorials about speed-running were mostly still relevant. She'd record new ones eventually , but having them to fall back on was nice.

"I'm ordering pizza. Y ou want some?"

"Sounds great."

Scorpia and Perfuma would understand. They knew it was always fifty-fifty if Catra or Entrapta would actually take to whatever vegan thing they brought home. And it never went to waste.

They sat in silence, Catra playing her game, Entrapta scrolling through analytics. She'd retreat to her basement apartment eventually, but she enjoyed company every so often. This happened to be one of those times.

"Oh, you have an email from Bright Moon Game Con," Entrapta spoke up. Catra *really* need to change her email password.

"Y eah," Catra said without looking away from her game.

"Y ou got it three days ago and didn't respond."

"Sure did."

Entrapta tilted her head, thinking things over. "Y ou don't want to go?"

"Not as a panelist or guest gamer , no. Maybe we can get tickets or something."

"Why don't you want to go as a guest gamer?"

Catra sighed, hitting pause, and spun to at Entrapta. "Do I look like the kind of person who goes to video game conventions and talks to

people?"

"Your anxiety has gotten *a lot* better since you started on medication. Isn't that what helped you get back into gaming?"

"Yeah, but I'm not putting myself back into the spotlight or anything. The last thing I need is drama."

Entrapta's eyes lit up as understanding set in. "Oooooh, you're worried about about another Catradora vs Glimmadora incident."

Catra groaned, covering her face. "*Please* don't use those stupid names. But yes. No one's asked about it so far, and I'd like to keep it that way. Putting myself out in the public like that is just asking for trouble."

She turned back to save her video game and booted up a Pokémon randomizer instead. She needed something mindless. Entrapta was quiet, still staring at her laptop.

"I thought you didn't want to let that drama run your life anymore," she said after a moment. Catra blew out a long breath.

"I *don't*, but that doesn't mean I want to invite it back into my life, either."

"Do you *want* to go to the convention? As a panelist, not just a regular guest."

She did, actually. Maybe not as a panelist, but the final day of the con was an all day speed-running event for charity. *That* she was interested in. She'd played for charity quite a few times, and she enjoyed it. Doing something she loved for a good cause was basically her dream.

"I'm just saying," Entrapta said as she packed her laptop up, "if you want to go, you shouldn't let the past stop you. I'll let you know when the pizza is here."

Thanks, T rapta."

Catra watched her go, made sure she was out of earshot, then got up and grabbed her own laptop, flopping down onto the bed and going to YouTube. After some hesitation, she typed *BestFriendSquad* into the search bar and hit enter.

Their profile – an absolutely ridiculous shot of the three of them all squished together , grinning – was the first thing that popped up. The follower count was at a whopping fifty million. Catra hesitated again before clicking on the channel. Their most recent video was titled *BOW DIES (again)* || *Squad plays 7D2D*. It must have been Glimmer's turn to pick the game, Catra thought with a small smile. She always liked the weird end-of-world co-ops. Bow liked Animal Crossing and Stardew Valley and Minecraft. Adora picked whatever shiny game had gotten her attention that month.

It had been two years since she'd last looked at this page. She had blocked their twitter, their twitch account, their YouTube, *everything* in an attempt to avoid any and all reminders of what had happened.

She clicked on the video list, and saw a video titled *SQUAD AMA HOUR* with all three of them on the couch. Catra hesitated before clicking on it.

"*Hellooooooooo Twitch! Or YouTube. Wherever you're watching this!*" Glimmer said in her bubbly voice as she bounced back to flop onto the couch, leaning into Bow. "*Adora's watching the subreddit and chat, and we're here to answer all your burning questions. Adora, do you want to pick one to start?"*

"*Sure*."Catra swallowed hard at the sound of Adora' s voice. She *missed* that voice. It felt like something fundamental had been missing in her life until that moment. "*Uh, first question — well, most popular question so far seems to be has Bow proposed yet. Soooooooooooooo?*"

She smirked at the couple. Glimmer was staring intently at Bow, who was blushing. "*I'm not going to talk about my plans on a live stream!"* His voice cracked. "*Next question!*"

Adora laughed, going back to the screen. "*Okay, okay… we've got a couple of people asking about collab possibilities… oh, one person is asking about Mermista and Sea Hawk. We actually went to school with them! I think our style is a little too different for us to collab, but they're good friends*."

"*Wait, I want to go back to that first question,*"Glimmer insisted, elbowing Bow and grinning. He blushed deeper.

"*Adora! Find something else please!*"

"*I'm looking, I'm looking… oh, someone wants animal cameos. Sorry all, we can't let the dogs in here. They've gotten in before and it's been a mess.*"

"*A mess* I *cleaned up*,"Bow added in a grumble. Adora raised an eyebrow at him.

"*I can go back to the engagement questions*"…

Bow dove to grab the laptop, scanning it qickly . "*Oh, here's one for Adora. Hi Adora! Did you see… um…*"

"*Did I see what?*"Adora asked curiously , leaning over to look. Bow qickly pulled away .

"*Nothing*!"

Glimmer took the laptop to skim the qestion, and frowned. " *Oh yeah, it's nothing. Just stupid. Let's move on—*"

Adora took the laptop back, slowly reading the qestion out-loud. " *Hi Adora. Did you see that Catra is back online? She's already at the top of the Mario 64 speedrunner leaderboard*."

A tense silence fell. “*Good for her*,”Adora finally said, putting the laptop aside. Catra hit the pause button, looking away.

It hadn't really occurred to her to wonder how Adora would react to her being back online. Especially since she hadn't reached out to talk to her. But there was a reason for that. She checked the date of the video —about a month ago. She'd noticed a slight uptick in people trying to ask questions about *Catradora*, only because she had blacklisted the word, so anything containing that was blanked out. She noticed the blanked out comments and tweets and immediately moved on. She didn't want to get into that. She refused. It had taken years of paranoia and therapy and medication to finally get her back to a good place.

“Whatever .”Catra closed her laptop, looking away from it, as if that would somehow enforce her refusal to acknowledge it. “They'd known for a month, and none of *them* had reached out, either. Communication worked both ways, didn't it?

Melog jumped up on the bed, nuzzling against her leg and purring loudly. She reached out to pet the little black cat, smiling slightly when he tilted his head to put his cheek under her scritching fingers. “Hey buddy . I know I messed up, but you still love me, right?”

The cat crawled into her lap, making sure her hand followed him. She smiled. “Yeah, you'll always love me. Thanks.”

She scooped up her phone with her free hand, going to her email to stare at the Bright Moon game con email.

“*I thought you didn't want to let that drama run your life anymore.*”

She didn't. She'd already let it drive her away from her home, dream school, the love of her life.she couldn't get any of it back, but she could have this. She could go to this and face her fears and reclaim *one* thing she had loved so much.

"Am I overthinking?" she asked Melog, who purred back. Right, not getting any answers from him. She stared at her laptop for another minute before tapping reply and beginning to compose an email.

"Hotel reservations confirmed!" Glimmer said proudly, closing her laptop. They didn't really *need* a hotel—they lived about twenty minutes away from the convention center. But it would be easier to have one, especially on days when they were supposed to talk to people. No one was going to want to drive after *that*.

"This is going to be so cool," Bow said, looking up from the stove to grin at his girlfriend. His smile faded when he looked passed at her, at Adora, who was sitting on the couch, looking at the screen. Glimmer looked at their friend as well; her smile turned a little sad.

"You okay, Adora?"

"Yeah," Adora muttered, chewing on her thumbnail. She had finally concluded that Catra didn't have Twitter, but she was still on Twitch and YouTube. Adora's interest in speed-running had never expanded much beyond what Catra played—it was fascinating, but required far too much practice for her to ever accomplish herself—but she enjoyed watching Catra. Even if it was just watching her like this, with the sound off and Catra blindfolded. She was apparently trying to figure out how to run Super Mario 64 blindfolded. Speed runners were so weird sometimes.

Glimmer flopped down on the couch next to her, looking at the video. She raised an eyebrow. "Why—"

"Apparently running games blindfolded is a thing." Adora shrugged.

"Oh, I've seen a few videos about that," Bow spoke up. "Mario 64 is a *really* popular one to run blindfolded."

"There's no way that's possible," Glimmer said, grabbing Adora's computer and turning the sound on. Catra had headphones on and

was turned away from the screen while wearing the blindfold, muttering to herself. An unfamiliar voice was doing commentary.

"*It takes a* lot *of counting and listening for sound cues and footsteps. If she goes even one step too far, it could end the entire thing.*"

"Who's narrating?" Glimmer asked, frowning. Bow had rushed over from the kitchen, and was leaning over the back of the couch, wide-eyed.

"That's Entrapta! She helped me build our last rig, I got a bunch of parts from her."

"*Catra always loses a few minutes in the mirror room. And I can see why, it's really complicated, especially if you end up on the wrong side*—"

The game paused, and Catra tugged her headphones off. "*Entrapta? How long have you been sitting there?*"

"*About an hour. You don't talk much during these streams, I thought I'd help liven things up!*"

"*Entrapta!*"

Adora hit the pause button, looking away. At least Catra wasn't living alone in a mountain somewhere, which was what she had started to think after she'd so thoroughly gone off the radar. She was even living with someone. And... maybe more? Who knew. It was fine. Catra was allowed to live her life. Adora didn't care *at all*.

Bow rested a hand on her shoulder, squeezing. "I bet if you left a comment, she'd try and get in touch with you."

"Yeah, that's a great idea," Adora muttered. "*BestFriendSquad left a comment on your video.* And it immediately blows up YouTube. Besides, she knows how to find me. She doesn't want to talk to me. It's fine. I'm *fine*."

She really wasn't, and they both knew it. Glimmer and Bow exchanged looks, and sighed. "Okay , Adora. If you say so."

Bonk. Bonk. Bonk.

Catra frowned, turning the sound up a bit louder, listening for *something* – some kind of cue or of f note to tell her where she was. But there was nothing. "God damn it," she muttered, pausing to reset the game. Eighty-six stars. She was up to eighty-six stars blindfolded. If she could just *stop getting lost* in the mirror room…

Melog jumped into her lap. She petted him gently , taking a deep breath to calm down, and hit the A button to re-open her first file. She had to get one more star from Snowman's land, and she could move on.

The opening music greeted her , and she hurried back to the castle. Straight, count the steps, tilt a little to the left, onto the bridge, Lakitu skip successful, to the door. she fell back into her easy rhythm, listening and counting, pause, repeat. The run was pretty much over the second she got lost, but the little bit of extra practice never hurt.

Her phone went off, set loud enough to be heard over the noise, and she pulled the blindfold off, blinking a few times. It was dark, and she'd left her lights of f, so she wasn't immediately blinded, at least. Scorpia had texted about a movie night. Catra declined, saying she was busy, and turned to look at her screen, sighing.

"Okay ."

She erased her file and started over, turning away and pulling her blindfold back down. The first seventy stars were.. not *easy*, because nothing was easy, but she could allow herself a little room to breathe. And think. Her favorite thing.

"Catra!" She jumped as her door banged open. "Entrapta said you're going to that video game convention as a *guest*?

"Yeah," Catra muttered, pausing her game and tugging the blindfold off. "And Im kind of in the middle of practicing for it."

"Blindfolded?"

"Mmhm." Scorpia wasnt a gamer, although she deeply respected her friends and their art. "Gamers are all about showing off new tricks and trying to one-up each other. You can do a game in two hours? I can do it in two hours blindfolded. It's all about getting the followers interested in your gimmick."

"I thought you didnt care about followers."

"I dont, but I *do* care about making a good impression and making money for charity. People lose their minds over things like this. And it looks cool."

"Oh." Scorpia sat on the edge of the bed, watching Catra curiously. "Did you look at the preliminary program for the convention?"

"No, Ive been kind of busy." Between regular content creation and practice, she had no extra time. Scorpia had to remind her to eat most days. "Why?"

"Well, um. BestFriendSquad is on the schedule too."

Catra's heart dropped to her stomach. "Oh." *Duh! You idiot! Of course they're here, they're going to be there, they're like the most popular people on YouTube ever! Why* wouldnt *they be there?* "That's cool."

"Youre not worried?" Scorpia asked, surprised.

"What's there to be worried about? They fuck around with games, I speed-run them. We have nothing to do with each other." Scorpia raised an eyebrow, not impressed. "Look, Ill be fine. It's been five years. Im sure people have already forgotten about all that… shipping crap."

Scorpia's silence spoke volumes. "People haven't forgotten it, have they?"

"Not really ." Scorpia rubbed the back of her head. "It seems like it' s been coming up more lately."

"Probably because some asshole on Reddit asked about it." Catra rolled her eyes. "Whatever , it's fine. I'm done letting it run my life. Fuck it. Let 'em talk."

"That' s pretty brave."

"It' s stupid of me to let it keep getting in the way. I'm over it. Adora is over it. We're living happy lives. Why should I be afraid of being in the same place as her? I'm going to this thing, and I'm going to have fun, and I'm going to talk to people, and it' s going to be *fine*."

Scorpia didn't look overly convinced. Catra turned away to focus on her game. The con was in six months. She had a lot of work to do.

"I hate this game!" Bow whined as he was once again taken down by a zombie. It was... Adora checked the kill counter . The sixth time he had died in the hour they had been playing.

"Oh, come on! It' s basically Minecraft with better graphics," Glimmer argued as she shot a zombie. Adora went back to raiding the school, listening very intently for any groaning sounds. "There are even zombies in Minecraft!"

"Yeah but they don't look like... this!" Bow waved a hand at the screen, exasperated. The game was, admittedly , slightly more graphic than Minecraft. Just a little. Adora leaned back to look at her laptop with the live chat.

"A lot of people want us to turn on PVP ."

"Maybe next time," Glimmer said, turning back to the screen. "We've already got a pretty good co-op going on in this file. And Bow's death count is going to go *way* up if we can both kill him."

"Rude," Bow grumbled, putting an arrow through a zombie's head. He complained about the game a lot, but he was good at it, and he loved the bow and arrows. Glimmer was always their gun expert, while Adora preferred whatever blunt object she could use to beat a zombie down. Who need aim when you had a crowbar?

The subscriber sound dinged on the laptop, and Adora looked at it *again*. She hated when it was her turn to do this, it was so hard to split her attention. "Oh, new subscriber!" she announced. "Hello highly qualified space lesbian!"

"Hi!" Bow and Glimmer said in unison.

"Wait, how do you become a *highly* qualified space lesbian?" Bow added, tilting his head.

"How do you become a qualified space lesbian at all?"

They both looked at Adora, who stared back. "What? I'm not an expert on *all* lesbian things."

The sight of her name in chat caught Adora's attention. She looked over to read it. "*Isn't Adora more of a sword lesbian anyway?*"

"That's true," Glimmer said thoughtfully. "If this game had swords, I think it'd be perfect."

"It *is* fun," Adora said. "Maybe we could play it again on Wednesday."

Bow looked absolutely horrified by the thought.

By the end of the stream, Bow had racked up an impressive fourteen deaths and was clearly at the end of his rope. "I think that's all we have time for tonight," Glimmer said, patting Bow's shoulder. "We'll be back on Wednesday, same time, same couch, *probably* a

different game. Follow us in the usual social media places for updates and highlights. And don't forget, we're going to be at the Bright Moon Gaming Convention in September, so if you want to meet us, get tickets. Bye!"

They waved, and Adora ended the stream, flopping back on the couch. She loved what they did, but it could be really exhausting sometimes.

"So. Bow Hi Cam for YouTube highlights this week?" Glimmer suggested with a mischievous glint in her eyes. Bow grumbled, but wrote the idea down on their whiteboard. He was in charge of video editing, and it wasn't a *terrible* idea. Adora checked the chat one more time, preparing to close Twitch, when something caught her attention.

Did you see Catra is going to be at BMGC?

"What?" she said out loud, getting Bow's and Glimmer's attention.

"What what?"

Adora grabbed the laptop, going to the con's website and checking the updates. Sure enough, there was an announcement about Catra recently agreeing to attend the con as a panelist and speed runner for the Sunday charity gaming session.

"Oh." Glimmer's voice was flat.

"Hey, good for her," Bow said, trying to sound positive. "She's probably been working really hard on her anxiety if she can do that."

"Yeah." Adora set the laptop aside, staring at her hands. "That's great."

She didn't want to bother Catra—clearly she was trying to re-build her online persona, and Adora thought that was great, really. But going to a convention as a *guest*? That was a lot. Catra barely liked

showing her face on-screen. Now she was going to stand in front of people and talk?

"Yeah, good for her," Glimmer grumbled, standing and heading for the kitchen. "She can go to a convention but she can't make a phone call."

Adora wasn't the *only* person Catra had left – Glimmer and Bow had been her friends, and she had shut them out without a second thought. Glimmer hadn't really forgiven her for that yet.

"None of us have tried to call her, either," Bow, ever the peacekeeper, pointed out.

"She's the one who left! The person who *leaves* is the person who makes the call, not the other way around. *We* don't even have her phone number anymore because she changed it."

"Leave it alone, Glimmer," Adora said, standing. "It's not a huge deal."

She head for the stairs and up to her room without another word. Glimmer looked at Bow, who shrugged helplessly. "We can't make her talk to her us," he reminded his girlfriend. "And she wanted a clean break after everything that happened. You can't really blame her, can you?"

"No," Glimmer admitted, shoulders falling. "I just hate it and wish it didn't have to be this way."

"I hate it too."

While Catra was absolutely the one who had suffered the worst, they'd all lost something in that drama. And it sucked.

Welcome to BMGC

Chapter Summary

Things get heated fast.

TW : bits of general mean language, implications of non-existent cheating, etc.

Chapter Notes

Yes I added a fourth chapter. The entire story is written already , I'm just still trying to figure out how to break it up. It 4 should be the final count though, since It's only about 25k words.

Five years earlier

"*You know, I'm starting to think you're just embarrassed to have me around*."

"That' s not true." Catra flopped back on her bed, staring at Adora' s face on her screen. "And you *know* that's not true. Im just… worried."

Adora and her friends were *popular* on YouTube. Weirdly popular. They had fans who *shipped* them. The BFS was sometimes a poly throuple, sometimes Glimmadora was the crowning ship (poor Bow), and Adorabow was *always* the top brotp. Surprisingly few people shipped Glimmer and Bow, despite them being an *actual* couple. People wrote fanfiction about them and made videos on TikTok of all the times one person looked at another set to romantic songs, which *proved* they were in love.

Catra was moderately popular, mostly in the speedrunning community, which allowed her to keep her privacy for the most part.

She had about ten-thousand followers on Twitter and YouTube, and none of them were weird about her personal life. She wanted to keep it that way.

But she also really, *really* liked Adora. She might have to sacrifice that privacy soon. And that would be fine. But they had to do it gradually, like introducing a cat to a new home. The little BFS fandom might explode if a new element was brought in without warning.

"*They're not… that bad,*"Adora said half-heartedly .

"Yes, they are."She knew they were. She had seen the fanfiction and the fanart.

"*Okay, they are. But that doesn't mean I can't visit you every once in awhile.*"She put on the puppy eyes. " *Please?*"

Damn it, Catra was weak for those eyes. "Okay . Maybe we can work on something."

"*Yay!*"Adora clapped, beaming. And Catra' s heart melted. Yeah. She was weak.

****

Present Day — Sunday — One day before the con

Catra looked warily around the giant suite Scorpia had rented for them. She loved spoiling her friends —her mothers had left her an extremely generous inheritance, along with the house they all lived in. They'd all assured Scorpia she didn't need to buy their friendship, but they weren't sure she got it yet. It was a work in progress.

"Scorpia, how much was this?"

"Don't worry about it!"Scorpia scooped her into a hug. "This is a *big* week for you. I want you to be comfortable."

"Okay , but you know Im going to look up the price and pay you back."

It was a three-room suite, and Catra couldnt help but be a little grateful —she needed a door between her and other people sometimes.

And she *really* needed it now. Years of therapy had helped her manage her anxiety, but this was a *stressful* thing, and she was feeling a little queasy . She flopped onto the bed, burying her face in the pillow and taking a deep breath. Okay. She was okay. She was okay.

She was signed up to talk at two panels, both group events so there was no one-on-one interaction, and then the charity event on Sunday. And she wasnt nervous about *that*. She could game without having to deal with other people. It was everything else that was the problem.

But she was fine. She had her Xanax for an emergency , and her regular meds, and she would be fine. Food. She needed food. She took a deep breath, pushing herself up, and went back out to the common area. Entrapta was trying to get the TV off the wall.

"Entrapta!"

"What?" she asked innocently . Scorpia, it seemed, had already given up on trying to wrangle her.

"Stop taking apart hotel appliances. Theyll charge us. Do you guys want food? Im starving."

"Oooooh, yes. How about Chinese?" Scorpia asked, already sitting up to find the menus. Catra went to flop down on the couch, pulling out her phone to play a mindless game. Instead she went to Twitter and looked up *@bestfriendsquad* . There was a selfie of all three of them taken outside the exact same hotel, grinning, and captioned *Buckle up BMGC, WE'RE HERE!*

Catra had known they would be at the same hotel. All the con guests were put up at the same hotel. She wondered what floor they were on, then shook the thought off. Nope, it didn't matter. She wasn't going there. She couldn't. This was better for them. Both of them. All of them.

"Here!" Scorpia happily presented Catra with the menu. Catra put her phone away and took the menu to find something to eat. Yup, eat, play some video games (if Entrapta didn't take the TV apart) and she would be fine. She didn't need to think about Adora. It would just hurt her more.

"Entrapta, if you leave the TV in one place, we can play Mario Kart while we eat."

Entrapta tilted her head, clearly torn between two desires – the need to take things apart, and the need to play video games.

"Two-hundred CC, all items," Catra added, trying to make it sound more appealing. It worked; Entrapta lit up, clearly pleased.

"Sold!"

"Adora, we're going to freeze to death," Glimmer complained, trying to get to the AC controls. Adora stood guard, arms crossed.

"And we'll die of heat stroke if you set the temperature. Ask for another blanket if you get cold."

"My hands are freezing!"

"I'll buy you some gloves."

"*Adoooooooooora*."

Bow had already tucked himself into his and Glimmer's shared bed and was watching in amusement. It wasn't the first time they'd

shared a hotel room. The girls had already argued twice about what temperature they were going to keep the room at while they were here. Adora always wanted cold, Glimmer always wanted it warm. Bow knew not to take sides. Especially since Adora almost always won. Neither of them noticed if the other changed it while they slept, and Adora was always up later than Glimmer.

"Come on, Glimmer . I packed you a pair of sweatpants and a long-sleeved shirt. Besides, now we can cuddle more!"

"I want to cuddle for *fun*, not to preserve body heat because Adora turns our room into the arctic tundra," Glimmer grumbled, rubbing her hands together as she went to crawl into bed with Bow. Adora puffed out her chest, proud of herself, and went to flop on her own bed, grinning a grin of triumph. The temperature would get changed two or three more times before they actually went to sleep, and they all knew it, but this was a rare moment of peace.

Adora slid her phone out of her pocket, going to YouTube. Catra's last video, posted yesterday, had been about how she was going to be gone for a week for the convention. Was she here now? All the guests were kept in the same hotel, which was attached to the convention center. It probably wouldn't be too hard to find her .

But she didn't want that. Adora had to keep reminding herself that. Catra didn't want to see her . Catra could contact her any time, they were *all over* social media, but she didn't. She didn't want to talk. That was fine. Adora could live with it. It *hurt*, but Adora could live with it.

She had to figure out a way to live with it.

Five Years Ago

Catra couldn't breathe.

She couldnt move, or close her mouth, or *think* as she stared at her Twitter feed. The site had basically blown up over a photo someone had posted of her and Adora, at a distance, sitting in a nearby coffee shop. She was vaguely aware of Adora behind her now, on the phone with Glimmer, attempting to get some details on what had happened while they had been napping after their coffee date.

Who the fuck is that

What about #glimmadora????

Ugh, Adora can do way better. Ugly bitch

Homewrecker!

Hey, she's a gamer too. Wildcat on Twitch and YouTube

#catradora?

Honestly, Catra didnt care about the comments on her appearance, or the insults. Internet people were ugly little trolls, that was the way of the world. But this was so much more than a few trolls.

"Hey , stop reading replies,"Adora scolded her gently , closing her laptop and pulling her into a hug. "It' s okay. Maybe now people will finally accept that Glimmer and Bow are dating."

"Y eah."Catra buried her face in Adora' s shoulder, feeling a bit hollow. "Maybe."

Present Day — Monday — Con Day One

"W e've been here for five minutes, how did we already lose Entrapta?"Catra asked, scanning a map of the convention. They were near artist alley, and had apparently left their friend behind… somewhere.

"I'm not sure, but she' s not answering her phone,"Scorpia said, frowning.

Did she even *bring* her phone to Bright Moon?

"You know, I'm... I'm not sure."

"Exactly." Catra sighed, shoving the map in her bag. "We'll find her later." Whether that was before or after she blew her entire life's savings remained to be seen. "Come on. There are a few artists I wanna check out."

Catra wasn't rich by any means, but she made enough to get by, with a little extra for fun things every now and again. And she'd been saving for awhile to get some good art from the convention. And there was one artist who did amazing Legend of Zelda work that she wanted to try and find.

Scorpia wasn't a gamer, but she could appreciate talent when she saw it. And everyone in artist alley was *talented*. She was waylayed every few seconds to stop and stare at displays, wide-eyed, and Catra knew she was going to lose her before long as well.

She found the artist she was looking for, and dropped fifty dollars on an *extremely* detailed drawing of Link in his Breath of the Wild shirt with a bad-ass prosthetic right arm. They spent about ten minutes debating over the scant details that had been released about the mysterious sequel before Scorpia eventually caught up to her, and more customers came in.

"That didn't look too bad," Scorpia said brightly as they moved along.

"She's amazing," Catra said, staring at the art. "I want to try and circle back if I can."

"I mean, the art is nice too, but I meant you *talking* to someone." Scorpia elbowed her, smiling. "Maybe this won't be so bad after all."

Catra carefully tucked the piece into her bag, shrugging. "Yeah. Maybe."

Their next stop was an enamel pin table, where Catra was finally able to complete the collection of Eeveelutions pins on her bag, and got a set of three pins from Zelda ~~a~~ mask, the shield, and an ocarina. Maybe *she* was the one who had to worry about blowing her life's saving. She also picked up a Porygon and Weighted Companion Cube pins for Entrapta.

A few people actually stopped to talk to Catra while they walked, and Scorpia was worried for a minute that she'd have to run interference. But Catra relaxed, smiling nervously, answered their questions, and even signed someone's Mario art.

"Did you get that here?" she asked curiously, looking it over. It was Mario with the winged cap, flying over the 64 version of the castle, with *tons* of small details underneath from other games. She could see Rosalina surrounded by Lumas, standing next to the Comet Observatory, Cappy and the Odyssey, and different regional coins from Odyssey scattered among the details.

"No, I drew it. I'm trying to get all the Mario runners to sign it this weekend."

Damn. Catra handed it back, feeling a little bad that she had defaced it with her messy signature. "Well it looks really, really, *really* good."

The kid beamed. "Thank you!"

She might not have realized it, but she was really and truly in her element here. Scorpia had never seen her this at ease around other people. They had met after...everything, when Catra's guard had been firmly in place and letting *anyone* in had been a challenge for her. But she was doing so well now. Scorpia was proud of her.

"This is *amazing*!" Glimmer said happily as she looked around, the VR headset completely obscuring her sight. Bow had his phone out and was recording for TikTok while Adora tried not to laugh. "Guys, we need one of these."

"I don't think our living room is a safe place for a VR headset."

"But imagine what we could do! The *games* we could play!"

"What, do you want to put me in a horror game in virtual reality too?" Bow asked.

"I would *never* do that to you."

"Imagine Minecraft in VR," Adora said thoughtfully.

"*That* would be fun."

"We *need* one of these," Glimmer insisted, face flushed, as she took the headset off and hurried back to her friends. "Seriously, it's amazing. I will never ask for any presents again for my birthday or holidays or anything."

"No horror games," Bow said firmly.

"Booooooooow."

Glimmer sighed, taking her phone to post the video on TikTok. They stopped at a table with hand-knitted stuffed animals. Adora smiled sadly when she saw Umbreon. Bow had decided once to assign all of them Eeveelutions – he was Sylveon, Glimmer was Flareon, Adora was Espeon, and Catra was Umbreon. She had taken the joke a *little* far, buying Catra a bunch of Umbreon merchandise, including three different pins for her bag (because she absolutely loved enamel pins, they were her favorite things) and two stuffed animals. Catra had made a show about being exasperated by the joke, but she had also loved it, and had bought quite a few Espeon things for Adora in turn.

"How much for the Umbreon?" she asked the person running the table. Glimmer and Bow gave her sideways looks, but she ignored them as she got her money out and bought the hand-knitted Umbreon, tucking it into her bag.

"W ow," Scorpia said in awe as she watched someone test out the VR set. She didnt understand how people managed to get around with those things on their heads. She was all thumbs. Catra had wandered to a nearby table, where there were hand-knitted stuffed animals.

"Any Umbreons?" she asked hopefully . The vendor shook his head.

"Sold that one an hour ago. Sorry ."

"Ah well." It was stupid anyway . A stupid little tradition that she should have given up years ago. "How much for Espeon and Mimikyu?"

Scorpia came back to her as she paid. "Here," Catra of fered her the Mimikyu without much fanfare. "I know you think that one' s cute."

"Oh, he *is*!" Scorpia said happily , taking the Mimikyu and hugging it tight. Catra thought they had a lot in common, and it was funny — people thought Scorpia was big and scary, but she was really just a giant, huggable marshmallow. "Thank you!"

They *finally* found Entrapta fawning over some custom rigs and talking rapid technobabble with one of the vendors. She didnt *look* like she had spent her entire life's savings, so that was a good thing.

"T rapta," Catra called, lightly tugging one of her pigtails. "Y ou have to save some money for rent, dont forget."

"I've only spent two-thousand so far!"

"*Only*." Catra shook her head. "W e also need enough room for all three of us to drive home in Scorpia's car."

"I know , I know. I just bought a tower , and I've got my eye on a couple keyboards, and a forty-nine inch curved screen"—

"She'll be back later ," Scorpia assured the vendor Entrapta had been talking to as Catra dragged her away by her backpack. She jogged to catch up with her friends. "This is a lot of fun!"

"Nerds are pretty fun in a big group," Catra agreed. "I went to a couple comic cons and always had a good time. And it's fun to support people. Most of these vendors are small businesses or just people working by themselves to make things work."

"Aaawww , that's nice." Scorpia looked enthused. "They might make a nerd out of her yet.

****

Five Years Ago

Don't read the comments.

It was the first, painful thing any YouTuber learned. Sure, it was good to skim them for ideas, but don't read the hateful comments too close, or they would drive you insane. And Catra was good at ignoring things usually. But she *couldn't* ignore these comments and tweets and Reddit posts. Because they could actually be a threat to her life.

Most of her comment sections were calling her a homewrecker, telling her to leave Glimmer and Adora alone. Some people were defending her and telling those idiots off, but the homewrecker comments were really getting to her. Like she was just some intruder in her own relationship. Like she was ruining something else just by existing.

"*They're just people on the internet* ," Lyra had tried to assure her when she had expressed her worry. "*They can't hurt you*."

Oh, if only her mother knew how determined and viscous internet people could be. It wasn't their *words* necessarily, although those *did* hurt. But she could shake it off.

No, it was the *threats* that scared her. The people who told her they would ruin her life. The ones who threatened to find out where she lived. They already had a pretty good clue from that first picture that had been posted — it was a coffee shop in Bright Moon, where she went to school, while Adora lived about an hour away. So they already knew what city she was in. They knew she was a college student because she had mentioned school many times in her live streams. There were four different universities in Bright Moon, so that was keeping her safe for now, but someone would narrow it down eventually.

People she'd never spoken to in her life were actually coming up to her on campus and asking if she was *really* dating Adora. She'd refused to answer, and one girl had told her she was a stuck-up bitch and Adora could do better. She didn't like that all of this was leaking over into her actual life now. She'd stopped going out for anything except class and food, stopped talking about anything other than the game while she was streaming. She didn't want to give people any more clues to finding her.

She *had* talked to her RA about feeling threatened, and she'd taken her seriously, thankfully. She came by to check on her during all her nightly building checks, and made sure she had her cellphone number in case something went really wrong and she was too afraid to leave her room. She also had her email address and Discord info so she could easily message her.

And she was grateful for that now.

The Reddit thread was titled *FOUND HER*, with thirty-thousand upvotes and seventy-thousand downvotes. It was a single picture — a picture of *her* dorm hall — attached to a post that read *Bright Moon University, Kytis Hall*. She'd reported the thread and screenshotted it to send to her RA, but none of that mattered. The damage was done.

Adora, Glimmer, and Bow had all commented on the thread with different, varying polite versions of *fuck off* (except for Glimmer who

had literally said fuck off), but by this point they were far beyond any damage control the three of them could manage. Adora was on Skype with her now, watching helplessly as she paced from end of her dorm to the other.

"*I could drive up and spend the weekend with you*," she suggested quietly.

"Oh yeah, that's a great idea. Give people *more* of a reason to hate me." Adora flinched away from the venom in Catra's voice. Catra paused, then blew out a long breath, squeezing her eyes shut. "Sorry."

"*I know you're scared. It's okay*."

Someone knocked on the door. Catra screeched, nearly tripping over herself. "It's just me!" Netossa called through the door. Catra hurried over to open the door, let Netossa in, then quickly shut and locked it again. "Hey. You okay?"

Catra laughed shakily, turning away. "A bunch of weird obsessive fans basically just doxxed me on Reddit and I'm afraid to leave my room. I'm definitely *not* okay."

"Has the thread been taken down, at least?"

Adora, presumably, refreshed Reddit again to check. "*Yeah, it's down. The mods have switched the subreddit to moderated posts only for the time being so no one can try and post any more info*."

"What does it matter?" Catra asked miserably. "People already have everything they need. All they have to do now is sit outside and wait for me to leave, then follow me back in."

"Well, we're obviously not going to let that happen," Netossa assured her, squeezing her shoulder. "I've already told campus police there's been a credible threat against a student's safety. I had to explain Reddit and doxxing, but they took me seriously."

Catra let out a long breath, beginning to pace again. "*Catra?"* Adora ventured again uncertainly. "*Can I come see you? Please? If anyone tries to break into the room, I'll break their heads*."

"And Ill pretend I didnt hear that," Netossa added with a chuckle. Catra looked at her, then at Adora, and nodded weakly.

"Okay ." Suddenly , all she wanted was to be in Adora's arms. To feel safe and to never move again. Adora let out a breath of relief.

"*I'll be there in an hour*."

"Im of f duty tonight," Netossa added. "Ill stay with you until Adora gets here. No one is going to hurt you. Okay?"

Catra nodded again, letting out a long breath. "Y eah. Okay."

****

Present Day — Tuesday — Con Day Two

"Entrapta no."

"But look at it!"

It was an admittedly gorgeous art piece of Chelle running through a blue portal on the left, with her legs still sticking out, and an orange portal to the right with her head sticking out. It was also *huge*.

"W ed have to *mail it* home," Catra said. "W e dont have room in the car with all the computer eqipment youre buying."

"Hat sounds fine to me!"

"Entrapta, *no*."

"I can ship it to you when I get home from the con," the vendor offered with a small smile. Anything to make a sale, but Catra couldnt blame him. She waved it of f and left Entrapta to work out the

details. As long as Entrapta could make rent ~~ac~~tually , even if she couldn't, it wouldn't matter . Scorpia would try to give her a pass.

"Ah, Catra!"

Oh god.

Catra grimaced as an arm wound around shoulders, tugging her into a tight hug. She had *never* been on hugging terms with Sea Hawk, but he was almost as bad as Scorpia when it came to boundaries. "What a pleasure it is to see you!"

"Y eaaaaaaah."Catra turned and easily slipped out of his grip. "Where' s your keeper"?

"T oo old to keep up with this shit,"a dry voice said. Mermista was a few feet behind, already looking exhausted.

"It' s only day two, Ariel. Better start chugging Monsters."

"I do *not* put that battery acid in my body. Saw you're on a panel for today."

"Y eah."Catra rubbed the back of her neck nervously . "The panel was around one-thirty, and Catra was trying not to think too much about it. "There'll be a bunch of way more popular people there, I'm sure no one will even want to talk to me."

"Nonsense!"Sea Hawk boomed in a voice that had several people looking in their direction. "Y our return to the internet has been a hot topic for weeks!"

"Y ou are *not* helping,"Mermista said, grabbing Sea Hawk by the ear and pulling him away from Catra. To Catra she said, "Just be yourself, everything will be fine."

"Really?Have you met myself"?

"I was *trying* to be supportive or whatever, but you said it, I didn't."

Catra snorted, but she had to admit, she appreciated it. "And *I* shall compose a sea shanty in your honor!" Sea Hawk said with a flourish.

"You will *not*," Mermista said, dragging him away. "See you at the panel, kitty," she added over her shoulder. Catra smiled, rubbing the back of her head. It was going to be okay. Everything was going to be okay.

130— Speedrunning 0 Learn about the basics of speedrunning from some of the best. Featuring…

"You don't even like speed-running," Glimmer reminded Adora. "Stop thinking about it."

"I'm not thinking about it." Adora shoved the pamphlet back in her bag. Bow patted her back.

"We should hit artist's alley again. I've still got some money left."

"Oh no, we might have some empty wall space," Glimmer said in mock shock. "The *horror*."

Adora smiled a little, but her mind went back the upcoming panel. It was entirely possible to go this entire week without seeing Catra — in fact, she was sure that Catra would prefer that. But Adora couldn't help herself. She just wanted to see her. Just once.

They were halfway to artist's alley when Adora said, "Ummmm I have to go to the bathroom. I'll be right back."

Glimmer looked at her phone, then raised an eyebrow. "Adoraaaaaaaaaa."

"Just the bathroom!" Adora insisted, backing up. "I'll be back in a few!"

And with that, she hurried off. Glimmer and Bow both knew where she was going, and it was no use trying to stop her.

She slipped into the packed panel, settling down in the back. The panelists were already sitting at the table on stage, Catra at the end. Adora felt her heart jump. She'd cut her hair into a cute pixie cut, and the lights cast a beautiful glow on her skin. Her dual-colored eyes were glowing. She looked… *happy*. Excited, even, to be sitting on stage and ready to talk.

The MC started with introductions and talking about the speed-running charity event on Sunday, then asked each panelist what they planned on doing for the event. Catra was the last one to respond, and her only answer was a sly smile and, "You'll see."

"Oh ho!" The MC chuckled. "Is this your big comeback?"

"Nah, I'm not making a comeback. It's just a surprise. I already cleared it with the organizers and everything."

Questions went to the audience, and everyone was very polite (even the ones who tried to get hints from Catra about what her big surprise was). She just kept that same smirk and refused to give anything away. Adora watched her longingly, drinking in every detail. She couldn't remember anything Catra said, but the tenor of her voice echoed in Adora's ears.

And then someone asked *the* question.

"Have you seen Adora?"

Catra's jaw clenched, her teeth almost audibly coming together. "Oh, come on now," the MC scolded the questioner. "We're here for gaming, not insane fan stuff from five years ago. Let a girl live."

Catra gave the MC a small smile. Adora slipped out of the room while the next question was being asked.

"You were *great,* Wildcat!" Scorpia scooped Catra into a big hug as soon as she was free from the panel.

"It was very impressive," Entrapta agreed. "And the lack of questions about Adora was surprising."

"And good on the MC for shutting it down." Scorpia kept an arm around Catra's shoulder. "Come on, let's get lunch. How're you feeling?"

"All right," Catra said. Honestly, she was a little giddy. It had been so much fun to talk about speed-running with other people who understood and could talk about ideas, and she'd always loved teaching people. It was part of why she'd made those tutorials.

"I knew you could do it." The unabashed *pride* in Scorpia's voice was a little embarrassing. Catra ducked her head. "Oh, and we have to call Perfuma later and let her know how it went."

"*Wow*, could you be a little less shameless?"

Catra grimaced at the voice, twisting out of Scorpia's hold to look toward the source. Glimmer was standing at the end of a row, arms crossed, expression set in stone. Bow was right behind her, rapidly mouthing *Sorry* to Catra.

"Got a problem, Sparkles?" she asked in a cold tone.

"No problem at all, it just a little rude to walk around with your girlfriend like you don't care about anyone else while your *ex* is here."

Catra scoffed, rolling her eyes. "Okay, Scorpia isn't my girlfriend, first off. She's just touchy-feely. Second, I'm allowed to *exist*. I can't help it if Adora's feelings are hurt."

"If her *feelings*—this isn't just about *feelings*!" Glimmer blew up. And Catra knew she deserved it, but honestly, Glimmer could've just

let them walk by. "Do you even care about what you did to her?"

"Do *you* care that your stupid fucking fanbase *ruined my life*?" Catra shot back. "Do you understand what I had to do just to feel safe again? *You* weren't the one getting death threats!"

"And your answer was just walking away? We were your *friends*! And you ditched us!"

"Okay, okay," Bow said quickly, stepping between them. "Everything that happened was a lot. But we're all here now, and everything is okay, right? Maybe we could—"

"We're not doing *anything*," Catra said, stepping back. "It's all about *you you you*, isn't it? Fuck everyone else. Just leave me alone. I don't need to get involved in this bullshit again."

She turned and walked away slowly, waiting for Scorpia and Entrapta to catch up. "Uh, not to freak you out or anything," Scorpia whispered. "But people were definitely recording that on their phones."

Oh. Fucking fantastic.

"*Why* would you yell at her?"

"I don't know, I was just mad!" Glimmer threw her hands up in frustration. "All you've done this entire time is mope about her while she struts around like she owns the place—"

"She wasn't *strutting*, Glimmer," Bow said patiently. "She was just walking."

"With someone's arm around her shoulder!"

Adora had to admit, she couldn't imagine what her reaction would have been if she had seen that. Sure, it turned out to just be a friend,

but the idea of it made her blood boil.

Of course, someone had already uploaded a video of the confrontation to TikTok, Twitter, and YouTube. And now there was a *new* ship name going around — *Glitra*. People were speculating that *Glimmer* had actually been dating Catra, and now she was some kind of spurned lover. There was also another speculation — *Glitradora*. Bow, somehow, got to escape all of this bullshit. Apparently no one cared about the straight-passing couple. It gave them some peace to live in, at least. Lucky them.

Glimmer looked at her phone, sighing as the video repeated on silent. Yeah, she'd made a mistake. She could admit that much. It just… *bothered* her. Adora had been wrecked when Catra broke up with her. It hadn't even been a breakup — she had just *left*! She'd even changed her phone number! Did she even realize how much damage she had done? Did she *care*?

"*So how's the con going?*"

Catra flopped back on the mattress, sighing. "I am one-hundred percent certain you or Mom saw one of the *many* videos on YouTube."

She could practically hear Lyra grimacing. "*It may have come up*," she admitted. "*I'm sorry, sweetie*."

"Yeah." Catra tucked her arm under her head. "Like, I get it, she was hurt, but did she *have* to make a scene right in the middle of the hall?"

"*Sometimes people don't make the best choices when they're feeling emotional. That doesn't excuse it, of course, but*"…

But Glimmer was Glimmer, and she wasn't afraid to rip someone down when they were wrong. "*Are you going to be okay? At the con, I mean? Are people going to bother you?*"

"Probably , but I'm here, and I've already hyped up my Sunday game, so I can't just leave."

"*Isn't this all voluntary?"*

"Yeah, but.I'm committed to it. I'm not going to walk away ."

"*Mama would be so proud to hear you say that*," Lyra said fondly.

"Where *is* she, anyway?"

"*With her one true love, of course*."

"Jesus. Tell her she needs to retire already."

Lyra chuckled. "*I tell her that every night. I'm going to start dinner. Call if you need anything, okay? We love you*."

"I love you guys too. Bye."

Catra hung up and tossed her phone aside, ready to take a nap before they got dinner —and then something hit the hotel room door.

"What the *fuck*?" She rolled out of bed, storming out into the hall. Scorpia was trying to beat her there, but her suite was closer to the door. She whipped it open, and saw that it had been fully graffitied. Everything from *homewrecker* to *#glitra4life* had been scrawled in different colors and handwriting. She slammed the door shut and yelled, "Entrapta!"

She popped her head out of her room. "Yes?"

"I need you to find out what room the *Best Friend Squad* is in."

"Oooooooh. Okay!"

"I can *not* eat pizza again," Glimmer said. "This would be the third night in a row."

"How about Chinese—"

They were cut off by what sounded like a rapid fist banging against the door. The three exchanged looks, and Bow went to open it, not sure what to expect. *Catra* was not it.

"Um, what—"

"*You*," Catra snarled, shoving past Bow and walking straight to Glimmer. Adora, who was lying on her own bed, had gone stiff, wide-eyed. "You're paying whatever the hotel charges us to fucking clean *this* shit."

She all but threw her phone at Glimmer, who fumbled but caught it, looking at the picture on screen. Someone ~~—or~~ several someones ~~—ha~~d scrawled all over presumably Catra's hotel room door.

"Wait, how did you find us?" Bow asked slowly, closing the door.

"My friend is a hacker. How the *hell* do you think I'm supposed to go back out onto the con floor tomorrow? Was it worth it? Just so you could get a petty fucking jab in?"

"I wasn't trying to do—"

"You know what your fans are like! There's probably already *fanart* of—" She waved her hand in disgust. "*Glitra*. And *you're* not the one who's going to suffer, I am!"

"Do you *really* think we don't get any blowback from *this*?" Glimmer asked heatedly, standing and shoving Catra's phone back at her. "Do you think it doesn't hurt us too?"

"Oh right, I forgot about the time *you* were doxed and *your* parents were fucking swatted. Let me know when someone writes *homewrecker* on your hotel door." Catra shoved her phone back in

her pocket. "You could have done *anything* else, but you decided to yell at me in front of an entire hall of people because you *know* it's not going to come back to you. Sure, you might get a few shitty comments and people might sound mix your voice to make higher pitched and *more* irritating somehow, but at the end of the day, no one is really going to bother you, because *you're* not the enemy in this fucked up narrative they've all built. *I* am."

Bow knew that look in Glimmer's eyes – that heated glare preceding a storm. And it was far too late to intervene.

"Are you done with your pity party?"

"Ex *cuse*—"

"I *know* you were royally screwed over, everyone knows! Do you think we dont feel bad? Do you think we didnt spend *months* trying to fix it? Do you think we really just sat back and watched while the Internet tried to destroy you? We *know* how hard it was on you, how *dangerous* it was. We tried to stand by you and help, but you *ran*. You didnt even say goodbye. We know you were scared and wanted to get away, and we would have done whatever you needed, but you couldnt even be bothered to ask."

Catra was still glaring, but she'd gone silent. Her entire posture was stiff, jaw clenched. She hadn't, Bow noticed, looked at Adora yet, but Adora was fixated on her.

"I did what I had to do to keep everyone involved safe," Catra finally said through her teeth. "There was no *helping* after everything that happened."

"You still didnt even try," Glimmer said. "Say it all you want, but dont be surprised if we're a little pissed off at being abandoned."

Catra turned on her heel, walking to the door. "Let me know how you want to pay us back for the vandalism."

She didnt look at Adora once the entire time she was in the room.

Setting Boundaries

Chapter Summary

Glimmer threatens some people.

Catra sets the record straight.

Bow does... something.

Chapter Notes

There were a lot of comments about the BFS not doing enough for Catra in the beginning, and I feel like I should clarify - they did everything they could, including some things Catra didn't know about. The internet is just a wild wasteland and once something's spread, it's almost impossible to get it under control. But they were absolutely all over and trying to do damage control - Glimmer especially since social media was her thing. She spent a lot of time patrolling Reddit and YouTube and Twitter and reporting anything she found that was even slightly sus. The entire situation just grew beyond them before they realized what was happening. Unfortunately, at the end of the day, they're just YouTubers. They don't have the power necessary to stop something on this scale.

A second note - I waxxed some poetic meta about Glimmer and her motivation in some of my stories, if you're interested in seeing what my thought process looks like. tl;dr I do NOT think Glimmer is some terrible villain. Just impulsive and probably also has some kind of undiagnosed emotional disorder. https://catrasredemption.tumblr.com/post/696401335279632384/ive-gotten-quite-a-few-comments-on-my-current-fic

Five Years Ago

Catra was halfway through her transfer application, trying to figure out where to get her damn transcript. She didn't *want* to transfer — she loved Bright Moon University. But there was no way she could stay here, either.

"It's *my* fucking transcript, why do I have to pay for it?" she asked her laptop in frustration. "Don't I already pay enough to *go here*?"

There was a thump at her dorm room door. She froze, turning slowly in her seat to stare at it. "Hello?" she called uncertainly. She was at the end of the hall with two other rooms, and she knew their occupants had all gone home for the weekend. Other than Netossa at the other end of the hall, she was alone.

Another, louder thump. Catra stood slowly, grabbing the baseball bat she'd bought *just in case*, and started slowly to the door. This was insane. There was no way people were actually at her door to bother her about fucking *Glimmadora* vs *Catradora*. Why was Adora's love life such a hotly debated topic anyway?

THUMP.

Catra jumped, heart racing. She walked a little closer to her door, checking through the peephole. The hall was empty. She clenched the bat with one hand, went to open the door with another—

The door was *thrown* open, throwing Catra off balance and sending her stumbling back. She fell, slamming her head against the bedpost, the bat falling from her grip. She sat there, groaning, trying to blink away the stars in her eyes. Fuck. *Ow*. She blinked furiously to clear her vision, and got a good look at her door. There was a fucking *knife* in her door, pinning a picture to the wood. It was the one of her and Adora, with her face scratched out. Several other *unpleasant* words had been written under the picture.

"Catra?" She turned blearily to see Netossa at the other end of the hall, horrified. "Jesus Christ. Are you okay? C'mere."

She put Catra in her room and gave her something for the gash on her head, then set off with phone calls. Campus police, the RA on duty, and (for some reason) her girlfriend. Catra just curled up in the corner of Netossa's bed, keeping pressure on the wound. The RA and campus police had endless questions, but there wasn't much Catra could say except to repeat the story (with input from Netossa). The desk person in the front lobby mentioned seeing a couple unfamiliar people, but they weren't a usual worker in this building, so that didn't mean much. He knew they came in around ten and left about twenty minutes later. There was a security camera outside, but Catra doubted it caught much.

Netossa's girlfriend swooped in with a first-aid kit, telling the police and RA to back off. "Here, let me see your head," she said gently. Catra pulled the cloth away, wincing when the woman started probing it. "What did you hit your head on?"

"Bedpost."

"Ouch. Bit of blood, but nothing too alarming." She produced a penlight from *somewhere* and took Catra by the chin, shining the light in each eye. "Good." She turned off the light and waited for Catra to refocus. "Try and follow my finger with your eyes. Don't move your head."

Campus police was clearly baffled by having a student come in and just tell them to stop doing their jobs. The RA seemed resigned to it and was asking Netossa what else she knew about the online drama.

"I don't think you have a concussion. But you're definitely going to have a headache. Here." She started patching up the gash with gentle care.

"Thanks, Spinny," Netossa said with a small smile. The police and RA had stepped out into the hall to talk.

"It'll take a couple days to get your door replaced," the RA said apologetically, as if *that* was Catra's biggest concern. "Do you have somewhere else you can go?"

"She can stay in my room," Netossa's girlfriend spoke up. "I'll stay down here with Netossa and help her keep an eye out in case someone tries to come back."

The RA promised to do extra rounds, and the police said they'd keep a car outside for the night and check the campus, but other than that, there was nothing to really be done. Whoever had done this was probably long gone.

"Let's get you a bag packed," Netossa suggested while her girlfriend (Spinnerella, Catra eventually learned) went downstairs to make sure her room was fit for a guest. Catra packed up her laptop and chargers, then picked up her phone. She had ten missed calls from Adora. What the fuck.

She called back; Adora picked up on the first ring. "*Catra? Are you okay?*"

"Uh... why wouldn't I be?"

"*Some asshole posted pictures on Reddit and said it was your door*," Glimmer spoke up in the background. She sounded furious. "*We already reported it and got it taken down, just in case it was real — was it?*"

Catra sighed, slumping against the bed. "Yeah."

"*Are you okay?*" Adora repeated. "*Did they hurt you? Do you need somewhere to go? I can drive up there and*—"

Catra suddenly really, *really* couldn't deal with this. "I've got a place, and I'm okay. I'll call you back in a bit. Love you."

She hung up and blew out a long breath, squeezing her eyes shut. "You okay?" Netossa asked quietly.

"Yeah. Let's just get this done."

Present Day — Wednesday — Con Day Three

"*Hello*?

Catra pinched the bridge of her nose, swallowing hard. "Hey, Netossa. It's Catra."

"*Catra*!" It was hard to believe Netossa could still be happy to hear from her. She'd stayed in touch with the couple long after she had burned every other bridge in her life (partially because they refused to let her go), but eventually she had managed to phase them out as well. "*And here we were thinking you lost our numbers*." For two years. "*What's up*?"

"I um. I need advice." Catra felt terrible, calling them just to ask for help, but they were the only ones who had a clear objective opinion on things. They had encouraged Catra to transfer after the door incident, but had absolutely *not* supported her just cutting everyone else off, and had tried to talk her out of it several times, only to be met with the same fate in the end. Netossa would've been justified in hanging up the phone without another word.

"*Sure, hang on. Let me get Spinny. Everything okay?*"

"It's kind of a long story. I started streaming again not that long ago, and I got invited to the Bright Moon Game Con—"

"*We saw the video*," Spinnerella spoke up, sounding apologetic. "*Are you okay*?

"I've had better lifetimes, but I'll live," Catra said dryly. "I'm sure you can guess what's happened since then."

"*The crazy people are back?*"

"They even vandalized our hotel room door . I told Glimmer she's paying whatever we get charged for it."

"*That seems pretty fair. So what do you need advice on?*"

"I dunno...my life?" Catra flopped back on the bed, squeezing her eyes shut. "I have another panel tomorrow , and then the charity event on Sunday, but now I just want to go home. I can't even imagine going back out on the floor today, and there were so many vendors I still wanted to go see."

"*Do you think you're in danger if you go out?*" Netossa asked.

"Nah, I've got Scorpia with me. Remember her?"

"*Yeah, the replacement RA. I wouldn't mess with you if she's around*."

"*How've things been online?*" Spinerella asked. " *Anything sounding particularly threatening?*"

Catra sat up and grabbed her laptop, putting the wives on speaker so she could type. "Jesus Christ, Catradora, Glimmadora, *and* Glitra are trending on Twitter. Don't people have anything better to do?"

She clicked on Glitra just for the hell of it, and was immediately greeted by a retweet from the BFS account. The retweeter had added *GLITRA CONFIRMED?* Fucking hell.

The original tweet was a TikTok with the caption *Important message to all fans*. It had been pinned at the top of their timeline as well. Catra clicked on it, waiting for it to load. It was Glimmer, by herself, out in the hall for some reason. A window in the background showed it was still dark out.

"*A lot of you have seen the video that's going around of me yelling at Catra — WildcatGames on YouTube — yesterday at the Bright Moon Gamers Convention. There's a lot of history there, and I'm going to*

get into some of it in a second, but first I want to say that I was wrong."Catra blinked, stunned. "*I have a bad habit of getting ahead of myself, and it got the better of me. The thing is, Catra and I used to be friends. We didn't have a falling out or anything, there's no secret drama. You can find most of it online still. Catra and Adora were dating, fans got crazy about it and started harassing Catra, and she eventually shut down all her social media, including YouTube, and moved away from Bright Moon. And she cut us all off in the process. And as mad as I was at the time — and kind of still am — I don't* blame *her. It wasn't just petty online drama. People doxed her and attacked her in her dorm room. They swatted her mothers, who barely understood at the time what YouTube even was. We didn't condone this behavior then, and we certainly don't now. This*"—

The background switched to a picture of Catra's vandalized hotel room door, with the number blurred out. "*This is not okay. We're not just random characters in some fantasy world. We're* people*, and fans like this have the power to ruin our lives. I get dozens of DMs every day telling me to break up with my fake' boyfriend because I'm clearly in love with Adora. I've been dating Bow since high school! My mother's been trying to get us engaged for* four years*. And even if in some weird alternate universe I had any feelings for Adora, she was* happy *with Catra. I'd never do anything to get in the way of her happiness, or Catra's for that matter. All of this is insane, and it* needs *to stop. You get to log off at the end of the day and go about your life, but this* is *life for us. And if I see anyone harassing Catra between now and Sunday, I* will *punch you. I'll find all of your online info, and I'll ban you everywhere I can and blacklist you with every popular YouTuber we know. We didn't do enough to stop this five years ago, and people were hurt because of it. But this behavior is* not *going to fly anymore.*"

The video ended right at the three-minute mark. "*Well she sounded angry*,"Spinnerella said.

"*She should be. You all should be. It's bullshit*."

Catra scrolled down to the comments. A few trolls, a few weird shipper messages, but there were actually a lot of supportive comments. People promising that they'd also protect Catra if they saw anything, people apologizing for treating their lives like they existed solely for entertainment, people saying it was weird to ship real humans anyway.

"I'm going to go," she said finally. "To the con, I mean. Thanks for talking to me."

"*Not sure we did much to help, but you know we're always happy to be here!*" Spinnerella assured her.

"*Just don't wait two years to call again*," Netossa added sternly.

"Yes ma'am."

"Man, you really got people talking."

"Do you think I took it too far?" Glimmer asked nervously, leaning over Bow's arm as he scrolled through the comments on his tablet.

"Threatening to punch people might have been a bit much, but blacklisting them is actually a great idea. We should have thought of that before."

"I think it's great," Adora added, giving Glimmer a grateful smile. Catra had hurt her, but she still didn't wish any ill will on her. How could she? Most of this was her fault anyway.

The MC called that the panel would be starting in a minute, and Bow quickly stowed his tablet in his bag. Adora saw him patting his pockets nervously and tilted her head; he met her gaze and quickly gave her a thumbs up. Not an answer at all, but okay.

Today they were talking, along with other streamers, about the ups and downs of full time streamer life. The MC did a little shpeal,

ending it by saying that *anyone* who asked questions about non-existent romances would be kicked out of the panel. That made them all feel a little better. A lot of questions were asked about the transition from traditional job to streaming, something Adora *still* had anxiety about. She had been the last of the three to give up her job at a local coffee place to join Bow and Glimmer on full-time streaming, and that had been after nearly a year and a half.

"Everyone says chase your dreams, but no one offers to pick you back up if you fall flat on your face," she told one person. "It was scary giving up my job for something that uncertain."

"What Adora neglects to mention is that we would have happily picked her up and kept her on her feet until she found another job," Bow said, throwing an arm around her shoulder and grinning. "But she's also right. We were lucky since we were working together so we could kind of stagger things. Glimmer quit her job first since she was also handling all the social media stuff and forgetting to sleep. Then I did so I could focus more on technical things. I'm still not sure how Adora managed to balance everything at once."

"Coffee and energy drinks," Glimmer said dryly. "I found your empty cans in the recycling. How many Monsters were you drinking a day?"

Adora shrugged. "Not...many."

"More than two?"

"Do I have to answer that?" she asked the MC, who chuckled and shook his head.

They finally started to wrap up, and Adora saw Bow patting his pockets again. "Anymore questions before we let these fine people go?" the MC asked.

"Um, can I ask one?" Bow asked nervously. The MC looked surprised, but nodded.

"Sure! Always love a good surprise at the end of things."

Bow smiled, then took a deep breath. "So, obviously there's been a lot of stuff going around about our personal lives, and most of it is untrue, but sometimes people *do* remember that Glimmer and I are dating." Adora looked at Glimmer, who was staring at Bow with wide eyes. "During our last AMA, I think something like twenty people asked when I was finally going to propose, or when Glimmer was going to get impatient enough to just do it herself, and well... the thing is, I really like to wait for the right *time* to do something, especially something like that, because it's something important that I want us both to remember forever, but if I keep waiting for the perfect time, it's never going to happen, so..."

He slid from the couch to get down on knee in front of Glimmer, pulling a small velvet box out of his pocket. "Glimmer, will you marry me?"

Every single person in the room gasped, then stopped breathing. Adora watched as tears filled Glimmer's eyes, and she covered her face. "Oh, shoot, wait, no," Bow babbled, looking horrified. "I'm sorry, I know public proposals are weird sometimes but we talk so much about it that I didn't think you would mind but we can just forget all this, everyone erase whatever video you took, I—"

Glimmer tackled him to the ground, hugging him tight. "*Yes*," she managed to choke out through the tears. "Yes, yes, yes, yes, *yes*!"

Everyone relaxed a little, and a few people laughed as the room burst into applause. "That's a beautiful note to end on," the MC said, wiping a tear from his eye. "Everyone make sure you congratulate the couple!"

Bow and Glimmer eventually got off the floor, and Adora immediately hugged them as tight as she could. "Congratulations!"

"Did you know?" Glimmer demanded even as she hugged Adora back.

"Do you really think I would've been able to keep it a secret?"

Bow chuckled. "Yeah, sorry. I wanted to warn you, but"…

"It was better this way," Adora assured him. "Where's the ring?"

He suddenly looked a little nervous. "So I was trying to be cute"—

"You're always cute," Glimmer assured him.

"And I wanted to do something unique, so just…don't laugh, okay?"

Glimmer snatched the box out of his hand and opened it. There were two rings that looked like small bent arrows, which had been curved around, but the ends didn't meet. There was a small diamond in the arrowhead and fletch.

"Oooooh!" Glimmer squealed, grabbing the one that had to be hers (the other one was far too big and definitely for Bow's hand) and slipping it on her finger. "Look!" She presented it to Adora, bouncing. Bow grinned, clearly relieved this entire thing had worked.

They made their way back out onto the floor, and were immediately surrounded by people gushing and saying congratulations and asking to look at the rings. Adora slipped away while they were busy, heading off by herself. She was happy for her friends, she really was. They deserved all the happiness. But sometimes it was hard being the third wheel. Especially when she'd had the love of her life and lost her.

She was here somewhere. Adora looked around, as if she could find Catra in the crowd. She would've given anything for just one more chance to make things work. She knew Catra's room number now, she could go talk to her—

No, Catra probably wouldn't appreciate that. Her privacy was *everything* to her. Adora couldn't invade. Which just left her to stew.

She wondered if Bow and Glimmer would kick her out, or they'd find a new place and leave her in their small house.

Be happy, she reprimanded herself, shaking her head. She needed to be happy for them. She *was* happy for them. They didn't need her sulking.

"Ha!"

Glimmer proudly presented her phone to Bow. *GLIMBOW* was trending pretty prominently on Twitter. "You know, I didn't *just* propose for the social media clout," he teased. Their throng of well-wishers had lightened up a bit, and they'd noticed Adora was gone. Now they had to find her – not an easy task.

"Of course not, but it doesn't *hurt*, either. Especially since it'll get people's minds off Catra." Glimmer scrolled through a few posts, beaming. "Not sure how I feel about *Glimbow* though. Kinda sounds too much like himbo. They couldn't have come up with something better?"

Bow chuckled. "Do *you* have a better idea?"

"Of course not, I have better things to do than sit around and think of ridiculous ship names. I'm just saying, they could've tried harder."

Bow shook his head, shoving his hands into his pockets – and frowning when he felt a piece of paper brush against his fingers. He stopped, pulling out. "What's that?" Glimmer asked, tilting her head.

"Not sure." Maybe some crazy fan had slipped a death threat into his pocket. It wasn't totally out of the realm of possibility. He unfolded it, scanned the note scrawled on it... and laughed.

"What?"

Glimmer grabbed the paper to read it herself. The handwriting was familiar. They both would've recognized it anywhere.

About time, Arrow Boy. Congrats.

Catra retreated early to the hotel room. She needed a break from the crowds, and it wouldn't hurt to practice a little.

She'd gone to the panel with the BFS for reasons she couldn't really fathom, and sat in the back, watching right until the very end. She was sure someone had gotten Glimmer sobbing on video and was looking forward to seeing it on YouTube later.

She hadn't stuck around for well wishes, of course, but they'd get her message eventually.

Five Years Ago

Catra's phone rang again. And again, she ignored it. Lyra didn't.

"It's Adora."

"I told you, I'm not talking to her."

"You're really going to just leave her like that?" Lyra didn't sound overly impressed. Catra didn't blame her. It wasn't her best plan. It was completely cruel. But Adora would get the message eventually. And she'd be better off without Catra. Everyone would be better off without Catra.

Lyra sighed, rubbing her daughter's back. Catra buried her head under her pillow. "I think it'd be better if you talked to her. For closure."

"It's just going to make things worse," Catra muttered. A clean break. That was what they needed. It would be good for her, for Adora. For everyone.

"And ignoring her isn't?

"It's complicated, Mama. I can't explain it."

She heard her bedroom door open, and assumed it was Cyra checking in. A silent conversation must have happened between them, because the door closed again. "Mom's going to order pizza." It was amazing how they could talk just by looking at each other. "You're going to eat tonight."

"I'm not hungry."

"It wasn't a question."

Catra groaned, shielding her head with her arms. "Fiiiiiiiiiiiiiine."

Present Day — Thursday — Con Day Four

"You're chewing your fingernails," Entrapta said. Catra immediately removed her hand from her mouth.

"Am not."

"You were, but you're not anymore, so it's fine!"

"Do you want your xanax?" Scorpia asked sympathetically. Catra had been increasingly anxious all day, leg bouncing nervously when they stopped moving, fingernails fully wrecked by the biting.

"Nope. I'm good."

It was another simple panel, this one on starting out as a YouTuber. Technically Catra was *re*-starting, but the panel organizer had said she had an extremely unique perspective – technically an old hand, but she had been on hiatus for three years. That was what they were calling it – a *hiatus*. Not that she had been chased off the Internet by people with pitchforks and torches.

"You're going to be *great*," Scorpia assured her, squeezing her shoulder. "And I bet they'll do the same thing today where they ban any questions about, you know, the Best Friend Squad, so there's nothing to worry about."

Catra blew out a long breath, nodding slowly. "Yeah. I'm going to be great."

Scorpia's prediction was dead on—even before the MC did introductions, she informed the audience that nobody would be allowed to ask questions about Catra's relationship, or lack thereof, with anyone in the Best Friend Squad.

It made Catra feel a little better, but it also annoyed her a little. Didn't people have enough shame to *not* ask about that shit after everything that had happened?

The panel itself was actually a lot of fun. Unsurprisingly, there were quite a few people who wanted to get into streaming themselves, and a few people with failed channels who had a million questions for Catra—why did she stop, why did she decide to come back. She skirted around the dirty details, simply saying she'd had to step away for the sake of her mental health and focusing on the nerves that came with trying to re-establish herself after being out of the game for so many years. Catra relaxed as she spoke more, feeling relaxed. She could do this. She was confident. She was practically a professional. She was—

"*What about Catradora?*"

The question came near the end of the panel, right as they were wrapping up, and the MC still called for panel volunteers to remove the person. And something in Catra's chest broke—or snapped together. It was hard to tell.

"No."

She stood, looking at the rest of the panel. They were all exchanging wide-eyed looks and nodding her on. The MC gave her a stunned look.

"What about Catradora," she repeated calmly—a statement rather than a question. "There's probably a million stories on the Internet about it. I paid a friend to completely wipe my existence from the Internet and refused to go on it for anything other than school until I graduated, so I've never tried to find anything about it. Can you imagine going to such extreme lengths just to get away from the Internet, especially when it's so integral to every day life? Imagine being *afraid* to go online? Or to even go *outside*? That all sounds pretty dramatic, doesn't it? But that was my *life* because of *Catradora*. Because of—and please excuse me for what I'm about to say—absolutely *batshit crazy* people who think it's *okay* to not only ship *real people*, but to *harass* them about it. I got *death threats* from people for interfering with the *perfect* Glimmadora relationship—which never existed, by the way. I don't know if you noticed, but Glimmer and Bow got engaged yesterday. They've been dating since *long* before they started that YouTube channel. I met Adora at a YouTuber event and she was single. Actually, we met because she left Bow and Glimmer to celebrate some anniversary, and she didn't want to intrude.

"Now just stop for a minute, and think. You've met this gorgeous woman who is *absolutely* into you and kind of a disaster, and you like her too. I'm sure some of you know how that goes. But she's also basically a celebrity, and you know there's a lot of weird shipping stuff going on around her and one of her friends, and some of their fans are rabid. But she's cute, and you like her. And *maybe* you're a little cocky, so you ask her out."

She paused, taking a deep breath. The room was dead silent. "I did my best to keep it under wraps, *because* I knew about the fans, and Adora was very patient with me and my privacy. But we wanted to see each other, obviously. I usually went to visit her and just hid in the house. The *one* time in *two years* that Adora came to see me,

someone got a picture of us at a coffee shop near campus. And all *hell* broke loose. I was doxxed and attacked in my dorm room. My mothers, who lived three hours away, were swatted. I got actual, physical mail threatening my life, to the point where the campus mail room flagged any mail that came to me and sent it to campus police to make sure it was nothing dangerous before they sent it to me. Take a minute to think about how insane that is. I couldn't even get *mail* without weird security measures. I had to transfer schools and go offline just to escape it all. Just imagine that for a minute. And imagine that minute being every single day of your life."

Another pause, another breath, and she said, "So what about Catradora? It's *dead*. Dead and buried. Because fans can't tell the difference between reality and fiction. The lives you see us living online are carefully polished and clean and everything we *want* you to see. But we have lives behind the scenes, and what all of you do *can* and does influence it."

She let out her breath, nodded, and stepped back to sit down.

—

"Catradora is trending," Entrapta greeted Catra as Scorpia scooped her into a hug.

"Great," Catra muttered.

"Actually, I think it might be a good thing." Entrapta scrolled through the tweets on her phone. "There's a lot of *I'm sorry that happened* and *I never realized things were that bad* and some of the usual trolls. Now would probably be an ideal time to attempt rekindling your relationship."

"*Trapta*. I didn't come here to *rekindle my relationship*."

"But you *could*."

"But I'm *not*, so can we just move on? I'm starving."

A few people stopped them on their way to the food court to apologize to Catra or give her kudos for being brave enough to stand up like that. Catra mostly blushed and waved it off, trying to smile and say it was no big deal. She was laser focused on getting shitty con french fries and chicken strips and getting away from the crowd.

The rest of the day passed quickly. Catra was exhausted by the time they got back to their room for the night.

"Oh, someone left a gift," Entrapta said, going ahead. She picked it up, examining it. "It's for you, Catra."

She handed it over. It was a hand-knitted Umbreon that looked *very* similar to the Espeon one she had bought on Monday. A small note was tied around the neck.

I know that must have been terrifying for you, and it was really, really brave of you to get up on stage and say all that.

—A

Tears burned in Catra's eyes, and she hugged the little knitted Pokémon close to her chest.

"Pizza!" Bow cheered as he ran to answer the door. *Finally*. They were starving, and the pizza place had warned them they were backed up because of the con—

He threw open the door and stopped, blinking, wide-eyed. "Um"… Catra's voice cracked. She'd clearly been crying recently. "Is Adora here?"

"Ah." Bow looked back at Adora and Glimmer, who were both wide-eyed. Adora nodded vigorously. "Hey, Glimmer, why don't we go wait down in the lobby for the pizza?"

"Sure, yeah, of course." Glimmer practically flew off the bed, grabbing Bow's hand and dragging him down the hallway. Catra watched them go, snorting.

"Not very subtle, are they?"

She stepped into the room, closing the door behind her. Adora immediately saw the knitted Umbreon she was holding. "You bought this on Monday, didn't you?" Catra asked, meeting Adora's gaze.

"I... Yeah. Yeah I did. How'd you know?"

"I stopped by the same table and they said they'd sold their last Umbreon." She shifted the Umbreon to one arm and reached into her bag with her free hand, producing the Umbreon's knitted companion – Espeon. Adora almost laughed.

"Would you judge me if I said I've got a stash of Umbreon stuff back home for you?"

"Only if you judged me for the same with Espeon." Catra stepped forward, holding out the knitted Pokémon. Adora took it, smiling. "So did you see the panel online or something?"

"Oh... no." Adora blushed. "I was there. Sorry, I know that's probably creepy, but I just... really wanted to see you."

"It's a public forum," Catra said, rubbing the back of her head. "And... I went to yours, too. Arrow Boy almost brought a tear to my eye."

Adora laughed. "He didn't even tell me he was doing that."

"That was smart. You can't keep a secret."

"You don't know that!" Adora protested, but it was weak, and she was laughing. Catra grinned.

"Unless you've made some significant changes in the last few years, I'm pretty sure I do. Especially about something like this."Okay , Adora had to give her that. She definitely wouldn't have been able to keep this secret from Glimmer. "Look, I um.I .didn't really come here with a plan or anything, but I saw the Umbreon, and I just"…

"It was a gift,"Adora said quickly . "I'm not expecting anything."

"I know you're not. "That' s kind of the thing about you, though, isn't it? You just do things without expecting anything, and.how am I supposed to just ignore it?"

"I don't know.you've managed it this long."It was kind of bitter and low, but Catra didn't flinch away from it.

"Y eah."Her shoulders sagged, and she sighed. "I know I overreacted.a lot. And I can sit here and say I was freaked out and I wasn't thinking, but it' s all just excuses. And you deserve better than that. So I'm not gonna."She waved a hand vaguely . "I just wanted to say thank you. I'll go now"—

"W ait,"Adora said quickly , taking a step forward. "I didn't mean"—

"Y es, you did."Catra smiled ruefully . "But it' s okay. It's my fault. I did all of this, I have to live with it."

"Okay , yeah. But I still don't want you to go,"Adora said in a small voice. Catra stared at her in surprise. "I've missed you, Catra. A lot."

"I missed you too,"Catra said. "I regretted everything a week after I left Bright Moon. Moms kept saying I could still call you and fix it, but it felt like I'd crossed a line."

"I would've taken your call."Adora had kept Catra' s number in her phone all this time, just in case. She was sure Catra had changed it after everything that happened, and she never tried to reach out, but she wanted to be available if Catra wanted her.

"I know . You're too good like that." Catra smiled wanly . "I was a coward."

"You were scared," Adora argued. "There's a difference. And I don't really blame you. I didn't know how bad it really was."

Catra sighed, sitting on the edge of Adora's bed. "I didn't tell you. I'm sorry."

Adora sat with her, but kept some space between them. "I'm sorry I didn't take any of it more seriously," she said quietly . "I mean, I did. I know you were scared. But I never took the fans seriously *before* that. When it was just the three of us, and people talked about me *dating* Glimmer, we just kind of laughed. We didn't realize how… intense people were about it. It never bothered us. No one ever threatened Bow or anything. So when we started dating, it never really occurred to me that it would be a problem with you."

"Of course it would be," Catra said bitterly . "I'm a stranger to your perfect dynamic."

"But you were *my* stranger," Adora said. "And I should have fought harder for you. I'm sorry."

"You're not the one who needs to apologize," Catra argued. "I'm the one who ran away."

"And we're the ones who let it get too far in the first place." Adora dared to reach out and take her hand, giving her a gentle squeeze. Catra didn't pull away . "I'm sorry ."

"I'm sorry too."

They sat in silence for a moment, staring at the wall. "I finished my Eeveelution pin set for my bag," Catra said after a moment, shifting her bag Adora to see it. She laughed.

"They look great."

I was *very* picky about the bag ones since I take this thing out in public all the time."

Silence fell. It wasn't uncomfortable, just...familiar. And nice. Safe. Like coming home. "I um"...

"So"...

They spoke at the same time, and stopped, just staring at each other. "Um" Adora started again, but she seemed lost. Catra took a deep breath and threw all caution out the window; she leaned in and kissed Adora.

And of *course,* the door opened.

"Whoops!"

"Sorry!"

The door slammed shut. Catra immediately pulled away, blinking rapidly. Adora just stared at her.

"Should we rescue the pizza?"

"Absolutely."

They still had a lot to talk about. But Glimmer and Bow had the food, and that was more important at the moment.

Present Day — Friday — Con Day Five

Catra spent the night in the Best Friend Squad's room. She hadn't *meant* to, but she fell asleep on Adora's bed, and no one kicked her out. She woke up in Adora's arms, and it was the best feeling in the world.

Bow and Glimmer snuck out without waking them, and it was almost noon when they finally woke. Catra was first, and she was happy to settle in and wait for Adora. She moved just enough to text Scorpia

and Entrapta and let them know to go without her, then snuggled back into Adora's arms.

Eventually she yawned, pressing her face into Catra's hair. "Do we have to move?" she mumbled.

"Nope," Catra mumbled back. "I've had enough crowds. I need a break."

"Perfect."

They laid in silence until Catra shivered and snuggled closer. "I know who's controlling the air conditioner," she muttered.

"I run warm!" Adora protested.

"Uh huh."

They were quiet for a moment before Catra said, "I'm sorry."

"Didn't we do this last night?" Adora asked, confused.

"Not enough." Catra reluctantly rolled away to meet Adora's gaze. "I was terrible to you before I cut you off, and you deserved better. I know you all tried to make things better and it was just a terrible situation, but I took it out on you. And then I just left you. I knew it was wrong. My moms knew it was wrong. Spinnerella and Netossa knew it was wrong—"

"The RAs from BMU?"

"Yeah, those ones. They were kind of mother hens. Spinnerella helped me pack up my dorm and let me stay in her room until I left campus. She was pretty cool."

Adora brushed her fingers through Catra's hair, humming. "I'm glad you had people there who could help you."

"They'll be happy I got my head out of my ass and finally talked to you." Catra snorted. "They spent months trying to tell me I was being stupid. So did Mom and Mama."

"I mean, I don't want to agree or insult you, but"…

"You can. I deserve it." Catra sighed, closing her eyes. "I just threw away two years of a good relationship and an amazing person because I was scared."

"No one reacts well when they're afraid," Adora pointed out. "But… I wish you'd handled it better. Glimmer was trying to figure out how to get you to move in with us because it probably would have been safer. But I didn't want to force you to do anything."

Catra laughed. "I might have been more willing to listen to that."

"Well… dang. Should've just let Glimmer steamroll me."

Catra smiled, reaching out to press a hand to Adora's cheek. "You don't… really forgive me, do you? I mean, I know I did a lot of terrible things. I don't blame you if you don't forgive me."

"What if I do?" Catra had to resist the urge to pull away from Adora because surely this was a dream. There was no way she was forgiving her. Just no way. "I know we have a lot to work through, but Catra… I never hated you."

Now Catra *did* pull away, sitting up and recoiling. "*How*? How could you not, after"…

Adora sat up slowly, as if afraid that she would set Catra off. "I was mad at you for awhile, and hurt," she admitted. "But the more we looked into it, the more I understood why you did it the way you did. I wished you hadn't, but… I understood. How could I hate you for that?"

Tears filled Catra's eyes. She looked away. "You're such an idiot."

Adora's responding laugh was a little watery. "I know."

Catra tilted her head carefully to meet Adora's gaze. She was smiling, stupid and hopeful, and damn it, Catra had missed her so much. She scooted closer, letting Adora hold her again and burying her face in Adora's shoulder, holding her tight.

"I missed you." She wasn't sure how many times she'd say that, but it would be true every single time.

And of course, Adora's stomach chose that moment to growl. Catra laughed.

"Wanna raid the rest of the pizza?"

"Absolutely."

They spent the day in the room, eating pizza and exchanging stories about the last few years. Adora was *delighted* when Catra mentioned her cat.

"Can I see pictures?!"

Catra laughed. "I bet I can do better."

She video-called Perfuma, who picked up on the second ring. "*Hi Catra! How's the con going? Scorpia was gushing last night about how great you were at your panel*."

"It's pretty good." Catra smiled. "You busy? Someone wants to meet Melog."

"*Oh, of course, one second. Did you make a friend?*"

"Uh. Sorta." Catra tilted the phone so Perfuma could see Adora. "Perfuma, this is Adora. Adora, Perfuma. She's Scorpia's girlfriend."

Perfuma blinked, surprised, but hid it fairly quickly. "*It's nice to meet you. Meloooooog, where are you?*"

She grabbed the treat box and shook it. Melog must have immediately appeared, because she laughed, bent down, and scooped him up. "*Here he is. Say hi to your mama, Melog*."

"I'm not *Mama*," Catra muttered, but it was lost in Adora's cooing.

"Oh my *god*! Look at him, he's so *cute*. Where did you get him?"

"He kind of turned up one day after we moved into the house," Catra said. "Technically, he's the *house* cat."

"*But he likes Catra so much more*," Perfuma said, settling on the couch to pet Melog as they spoke. "*He's been sitting up near your door since you left and only comes down when I get home from work to see if you're with me. It's a fifty-fifty chance if he'll come down for food, or if I have to bring it up to him*."

"Aaaawww, poor baby," Adora said, pouting.

"Yeah, he's so neglected," Catra said, rolling her eyes. Perfuma was carefully feeding him treats from her hand now. "He's the *house* cat."

"*He's basically Catra's cat*," Perfuma told Adora. "*He'll have to go with her when she moves out*."

"It's cute that you think I'm going to leave your attic."

Melog purred loudly, trying to headbutt Perfuma's phone, like he could tell where Catra's voice was coming from. "So cuuuuuuute," Adora cooed. "Hello sweet kitty."

Melog trilled and knocked the phone out of Perfuma's hand.

Glimmer and Bow returned after dinner, with food for Adora and Catra, just in case. They were right, it turned out – the two were lying in bed, Adora half watching a movie while Catra slept on her chest. She looked very comfortable.

"Did you guys talk?" Bow asked, keeping his voice low to try and avoid disturbing Catra. Adora nodded.

"Yeah. Not as much as we should have, probably, but we started. And I met her cat! Kind of. On a video call."

"Aaaawwww, cat!" Bow said excitedly.

"That's cute," Glimmer said in a level tone. "But you guys *do* have a lot to work out, still. I know it's tempting to just jump right back in—"

"I know," Adora said. "We know. We're trying."

And that wasn't even getting into public stuff. That was a whole mess in and of itself. "We're happy for you, though," Bow added quickly. "And we know Catra makes you happy. And you make her happy. That's all that matters."

"Yeah." He was right, but there was still so much more to consider. Adora didn't know what to do with any of it. She just wanted to stay right here, cuddling with Catra, and never face the world.

Almost Perfect

Chapter Summary

The final con days.

Things get intense.

Chapter Notes

Let's go!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Present Day — Saturday — Con Day Six

Catra checked her hair in the mirror, frowning and trying to flatten it. "Are you trying to look better for your girlfriend?" Entrapta asked curiously.

"She's *not* my girlfriend," Catra said firmly . God forbid someone overhear Adora being referred to as her girlfriend when they hadn't *really* worked things out. Catra had retreated back to her own room the night before so she could shower and placate her friends.

"When does she become your girlfriend again? Is there some kind of milestone?"

Catra grabbed her bag, not answering, and headed for the door. "Let's try to keep it down, Entrapta," Scorpia said gently . "We've still got two con days to go."

"True. Okay."

There was a pause. "Please don't bring the recorder ."

"Hmph." Catra knew Entrapta was pouting. "*Fine*."

The con was carrying on as normal by the time they arrived. Entrapta immediately ran off to the computer aisle, and they knew they wouldn't see her until her bank was at least three-thousand dollars lighter. Catra and Scorpia went to artist's alley again, because it was the best place to spend time. There was a panel Catra wanted to go to in the afternoon, but there was plenty of time to kill.

"Are people staring at me?" Catra muttered to Scorpia as they walked.

"Nah. Well. Maybe." Scorpia waffled, rubbing the back of her head. "I think you really changed something with what you said the other day. People are talking."

"People are *always* talking." Catra rolled her eyes. "There's a reason I walked away from all this to begin with."

They stopped at a table with handpainted miniature models and handmade dice. Neither of them played, not for lack of trying on Entrapta's part, but it was always something Catra thought about.

She ended up buying a dice set for Entrapta, and they moved on. Her bank account was definitely suffering a little, but she could always pick up a freelance gig to make up for it. Rent wouldn't be late. That was all that mattered.

"How are people so talented?" Scorpia asked in wonder as they walked along. "Look at all this beautiful art! How do they do it?"

"Hard work and a lot of time. Kind of like Perfuma and her plants."

"Oooooh. Are there plant conventions?"

"I have *no* idea."

Adora was *trying* to be sneaky as she checked her phone, hoping Catra would text her. Nothing. Catra had given Adora her new number, so Adora could *probably* text her first, but she didn't want to be pushy. She could wait for Catra to come to her.

Hopefully Catra came to her.

"I bet we could find her if we tried," Bow suggested helpfully. "She's probably in artist's alley blowing all her money."

Adora laughed. He wasn't wrong. Catra had such a soft spot for artists and supporting them. "No. I want to give her space. She'll come to me when she's ready."

For the first time in years, Adora actually felt confident about that. They were making progress. It was going to be okay.

"You should try it."

"Oh, no. I'd probably knock something over."

"Imagine the views you'd get on YouTube, though."

Scorpia blushed, and Catra laughed. They were watching someone play with a VR headset. Scorpia was fascinated by the idea, but understandably nervous to try—she was a big gal with very little in the way of coordination.

"Can you livestream stuff like that?" Scorpia asked, tilting her head.

"Yeah, but you need some crazy setup that I don't have the patience for. I'll stick to computer games and emulators." Catra had tried a headset once. She didn't like how heavy it felt on her head. But she could definitely see the appeal. "This is something Entrapta would like. She can play and move at the same time. Her favorite thing."

"Wouldn't her *favorite* thing be taking the headset apart?"

Catra tilted her head, thinking. "Good point. Second favorite thing, then. Should we find her?"

"Probably . It's almost lunch time."

Catra took her phone out of her pocket, staring at it uncertainly. "Do you uh...mind if I invite Adora and her friends to eat with us?"

Scorpia stared at her, surprised, but smiled. "Yeah, of course. Ill go find Entrapta, why dont you grab us a seat?"

"Sure. Sounds good."

Catra quickly texted as she walked, getting to the food court just in time to grab a decent sized table. Entrapta was small. Glimmer might have to sit in Bow's lap. It was fine.

The Best Friend Squad arrived first —not really a surprise, since Entrapta could be hard to drag away, and Scorpia didnt really have the willpower to make her do things. Catra probably should have gone for her instead.

"Hi!" Adora said, a bit loudly , as she approached, Bow and Glimmer behind her. Catra looked up from her phone, smiling wryly.

"Hey , Adora. Sparkles. Arrow Boy."

"Hi Catra," Bow said with a small smile. Glimmer rolled her eyes. She'd always hated the nicknames Catra used for them. Or she pretended to, anyway. They all knew the scathing nicknames were a sign of love.

"Where are your friends?"

Catra looked at her phone. No desperate texts from Scorpia yet. "Probably still in the computer aisle. Entrapta's had her eye on at least ten-thousand dollars worth of equipment. We're trying to cap her at six."

"Who can af ford that kind of stuff?" Glimmer asked in disbelief.

"Entrapta. She makes *money*. She does like, government level work and has a side gig building rigs for people. Her cheapest package is like two-thousand for the absolute basics."

"*Wow*. Wait." Glimmer turned to Bow , eying him suspiciously. "Didnt you say you hired her to build our current rig? How much was it?" Bow was suddenly very interested in the ceiling. "*Bow*. How much did you pay this girl to build our rig?"

"She came with like a million recommendations—"

"Hang on, I know enough about Entrapta' s business to work this out." Catra leaned back in her chair , looking between them. "So there needs to be enough support for all three of you to play at the same time, on camera, with mics. Some of your games are really low impact, like Stardew Valley, and some of them are insanely resource heavy —how many mods are even *on* your Minecraft server? And you run a livestream and chat at the same time sometimes, so… three-thousand? Four? No higher than six."

Bow was sinking lower in his chair. Glimmer glared at him. Adora was clearly trying not to laugh. "Come on Glimmer , we leave him in charge of the money for a reason. I trust him. And our setup *is* pretty nice."

"I *suppose*," Glimmer grumbled, but she was still staring at the top of Bow's head.

"Gonna have to start penny pinching for that wedding, huh?" Catra said with a smirk. "Are you sure you're able to af ford lunch?"

"Are you of fering to buy?" Glimmer asked.

"Absolutely not. I dont have fuck you money ."

Scorpia slumped into the food court —notably alone —and dropped into an empty chair next to Catra. "Uh…where's Entrapta?"

"I couldn't make her leave."

"Damn it." Catra sighed. "Did you remind her we need room in the car to get home and leaving one of us behind isn't an option?"

"Uh." Scorpia chuckled nervously. "I… *did* mention that, yeah."

"And her response was?"

"That you could spend some extra time in Bright Moon with your… withyourgirlfriend." She rushed out that last part. Adora blushed deeply, and Catra looked away.

"Ugh, whatever. Go get your food before the line gets too long."

Scorpia gave her a small smile before hurrying off to get food. It was Catra's little way of showing she cared —letting others get food before her so they didn't have to stand in a long line.

"Let's get food too," Glimmer said, grabbing Bow's hand. "We can talk more about our rig setup."

Bow mouthed *help me* to Adora and Catra as he was dragged away. They did absolutely nothing. "Were you serious about the six-thousand?" Adora whispered to Catra.

"Absolutely. I've seen Entrapta's prices."

"Wow," Adora breathed, wide-eyed.

"Yeah. We really don't have to worry about her going broke, but she'll fill the entire car with equipment if we let her."

"How big is her apartment? Where does she put it all?"

Catra snorted. "Okay , so we all live in Scorpia's house. It's not small, dont get me wrong —three floors and a furnished basement. Entrapta lives in the basement. It has its own bathroom and plenty of space, and the walls are lined with bits and pieces of equipment. It' s a good space for her, since no one trusts her near a stove."

Adora tilted her head slightly, eyes going cross in that way it did when she was trying to figure out how to ask a question. "So..you live there too? Do you, um..I..mean, are any of you like..are you?.."

Oh. *Oh*. "*God*, Adora, no. Perfuma and Scorpia are dating, Entrapta is aro-ace, and Ive committed to the single cat lady life."

"Oh. Good."Adora sighed, then stif fened. "Not that —I mean, Im not *glad* that youre —I mean, if youre happy that' s all that matters "—

Catra covered her eyes with one hand and Adora's mouth with the other. "Sssssshhhhh. Stop talking."

Adora tried to look offended, but she started laughing, and Catra did as well.

Entrapta joined them about half an hour into their meal, humming to herself as she scrolled through her phone. "If there isnt enough room in the car, were leaving *you* here,"Catra informed her . Entrapta seemed entirely unconcerned.

"Itll be fiiiiiiiine."She looked up, tilting her head at Bow . "Do I know you?

"Uuuuuuuuh"—

"Oh!I built that rig for you awhile back. How' s it going?"

"Pretty good,"Bow squeaked out nervously , trying to ignore the look Glimmer was giving him. "Barely had to do any maintenance on it."

"I would hope so, those parts were the best I could get." Entrapta went back to her phone. "Oh, and Catradora is trending again."

The entire table went stiff. "*Why*?" Catra asked warily. Entrapta held out her phone – someone had gotten a picture of Catra covering Adora's mouth and her eyes, and captioned it *Lovers quarrel?* It had blown up, because of course it had, and was currently sitting at twenty-five hundred retweets and over six-thousand likes. There were, surprisingly, very few negative replies. "Jesus Christ. Whatever."

She felt a little better about dragging Adora away from all their friends after they ate, though. Maybe they could actually walk together without it turning into a disaster. She even dared to take Adora's hand. They were both blushing and pretending to be involved in looking at things very specifically *not* their intertwined fingers.

"So tomorrow's the charity event, right?" Adora asked as they explored an aisle of old video games.

"Yeah. You gonna ask what I'm doing?"

Adora scoffed. "No. I know what you're like with your secrets. You wouldn't tell me."

Catra grinned. "It'll be worth the wait, I promise." She paused, then added, "Not that I expect you to come or anything – I know it's the last day of the con, too—"

"And I've spent all the money I budgeted. Besides, Bow and Glimmer probably want at least *one* day for themselves."

"Ah yes, *Glimbow* probably wants some time in the spotlight."

Adora choked as she tried not to laugh. "Yeah, it's um...it's not a *great* name."

"Did you see the threesome name for us and Glimmer?"

"Glitradora? Yeah." Adora smirked faintly. "I think *Glitra* has a name ring to it, though."

"Absolutely not." Catra pretended to gag. "I would rather date... I don't know, *anyone* else."

"Bow?"

"Almost anyone else."

"What would people even *call* that? Bowtra? Cabow?"

"Well, we know who's *not* allowed to create ship names." Catra rolled her eyes.

"Like any of the other names are *really* any better."

It was nice, Catra thought as they walked along, to just be able to joke about this. She was still anxious, of course, but she felt more secure now. Safe. At home with her hand in Adora's.

"Oh, hey." Catra dragged Adora to a table of keychains. "Check these out."

They were Pokémon keychains, split into two halfs so they could be mixed and matched. Catra picked out an Umbreon and an Espeon that could be connected.

"I *just* told you I spent all my money," Adora said, exasperated. Catra rolled her eyes.

"Obviously I'm getting it for you. We have to own all the Espeon and Umbreon things, right?"

The vendor looked *slightly* starry-eyed. "Is that like, a couple thing?" he asked, looking between them.

"Sorta. A friend decided I'm Umbreon and she's Espeon, and we took it and ran with it."

Catra handed her card over, and gave Adora the Espeon keychain. "I *did* need a new keychain," she admitted, smiling. "Thanks."

They continued on, talking about a little bit of everything and nothing. They ignored the looks they got, the good and the bad, they explored, and they enjoyed being together.

But it was still crowded, and Catra was definitely over her "dealing with people" threshold. Adora, luckily, still recognized the signs of Catra getting overwhelmed. "Do you want to leave?" she asked quietly. Catra blew out a long breath, nodding. But she wasn't ready to part with Adora quite yet.

"Wanna come back to my room?"

Adora lit up. "Yeah. That'd be great."

They texted their friends to let them know where they were going, then went back to the hotel. "Wow," Adora said in disbelief as she looked around the three-room suite. "How are you even affording this?"

"Scorpia's kinda...rich. Inheritance. That's how we afford the house, too. She has a decent job too, and she loves spending money on her friends. She knew this was a big deal, so she splurged a little. I'm paying her back next month when I pay rent, though. I don't like feeling like I'm taking advantage of her."

She led Adora into her room, dragging her to lie down on the bed with her. They curled up together, Adora holding Catra close.

They laid silently for a few minutes before Catra's phone went off. Adora made a protesting noise, pulling Catra closer. "It's my moms' ringtone," Catra said, pulling away to check the caller ID. It was Cyra. "Hey Mom, what's up?"

"*I'm a little insulted that we have to find out our daughter's relationship status on* Twitter *of all things, to start*."

Catra rolled her eyes. "There isn't a relationship. You know what the Internet is like. People are just talking."

"*Mmhm. And where are you now?*"

"Hanging out with Adora, but that is absolutely *not* the point."

"*Right*." Cyra had that smug, all-knowing tone in her voice. Catra really wished Lyra had been the one to call — she was at least a little more subtle about her teasing. "*Well, we're glad and we approve, for whatever that's worth. Adora was good for you. I'm sure she still is*."

Adora, of course, could hear all of this, and was smiling proudly, chest puffed up. "She's all right," Catra said, poking Adora in the side. Adora squeaked, letting out the breath she was holding.

Present Day — Sunday — Con Day Seven

"You okay?"

"Yup."

Adora wasn't sure she believed that. Catra looked pale, and possibly like she was going to throw up. It had been a long time since she'd participated in any big events, and it was perfectly reasonable for her to be nervous.

"Xanax?" Scorpia offered gently. Catra still had an hour before her slot opened — gamers were running concurrently, and Catra was scheduled to take over after a Sonic speed run.

"Um. Yes." She'd managed to get through the week without it, but she needed to not be freaking out right now. Scorpia dug the bottle out of her bag and handed it over. Adora tilted her head, watching Catra.

"Don't judge me."

"I'd never judge you," Adora said, frowning. "I'm just glad you got some help. I know you had a hard time with anxiety even without all of—" She waved her hand. "I'm happy for you."

Catra smiled weakly, blew out a long breath, and threw the pill back. She quickly took several large sips of her water to wash out the chalky taste. Disgusting. "And you're going to be great," Scorpia added.

"Are you going to tell us what you're doing *now*?" Adora asked, trying to distract Catra. It worked. Catra gave her a smirk.

"You can wait an hour."

"Wait, what's that guy doing?" Scorpia asked, pointing to a screen that was running Stardew Valley.

"Exploiting a glitch to finish the game in under thirty minutes."

Scorpia frowned, tilting her head. "What's the point of that? I mean, you're not even really playing the game at that point."

"It's about being flashy and cool."

"Oooooooh." She pointed to another screen. "What's that one?"

"Fallout New Vegas. That one is so easy to break."

"Is. Is the character *flying*?"

"I'll explain later."

Catra took another sip of water. She was fine. This was going to be fine. Scorpia scanned the program, then frowned.

"Hey Wildcat, I think there's a typo. You've got a five-hour block."

"Nope, that's right."

Scorpia raised an eyebrow at her. "Really?"

Catra looked at the Sonic run. It had about thirty minutes left. "Y up. Don't worry about it, Scorp. Really."

Adora was just as curious, but she didn't want to bother Catra. Scorpia had that rapport with her now. Adora wasn't sure if they were there yet.

Someone called Catra's name eventually. She grimaced, swallowing hard. "You got this," Scorpia said. Adora squeezed her shoulder.

"Yeah. I got this."

Catra stood, following the coordinator to her spot. Scorpia and Adora moved to get a better view of the screen she would be on. It took ten minutes for her to set up before the stream finally began. Catra looked far more confident on screen than she had when she had walked away.

"*What's up guys?*" She smiled that cocky smile that made Adora's stomach flip. "*Ready for something fun?*" She held up a blindfold. "*Mario 64, one-hundred and twenty stars, blindfolded, live debut*."

"Whoa," Scorpia breathed. Adora blinked, eyes widening. She didn't know much about speed-running, but she knew this was a big deal. "I knew she was practicing that, but I didn't think…"

"Oh good, just in time!" Entrapta said as she flopped next to Scorpia. They watched as Catra donned her blindfold, made a show of turning away from the screen so she could show that she *really couldn't see*, and hit the A button to start her new game. "She ended up going with five hours, huh? Her best time in practice was five hours and five minutes, but I guess she felt confident when she submitted it."

"Wait, you knew she was doing this?"

"Yeah, she's been practicing for months. Oh, look, she hit the Lakitu skip! That's hard to get sometimes."

"The.what?"

"The Lakitu skip. In a regular game, when you hit the bridge, the Lakitu controlling the camera will come down and explain how to use the camera to you. But if you jump juuuuuuuuuust right, you can skip it. It takes a bit of practice and especially getting it blindfolded can be difficult. Oh, this seems like a good bomb-omb run so far."

"So..how does she do it?" Adora asked curiously, because she couldn't wrap her head around the concept. "Did she memorize the map?"

"Nah, that'd be too easy." It didn't *sound* easy to Adora, but okay. "There's *some* muscle memory involved, but mostly she has to follow sound cues. There are areas where she can find corners to establish where she is, but I'd say about ninety percent of it is sound. Those are her best headphones – they were five-hundred dollars if I remember correctly, but they're completely sound canceling. I can sit in the room and talk for hours without her noticing. And I have."

Adora looked back up at the screen. It had been about twenty minutes, and she was up to ten stars. Entrapta looked up as well, tilting her head. "She's a star behind. That Lakitu skip definitely saved her a few seconds, so that might work in her favor – she couldn't get it consistently in practice."

A few more people had gathered around behind Entrapta to listen to her commentary. Catra couldn't talk while she was playing, which was a shame because she could have probably explained this just as well, but Entrapta gave it a little more zest.

"What about the red coins and secret coins?" someone else asked. "One-twenty includes those too, doesn't it?"

That *does* need to be memorized a little, but coins are static. It's not like the Bomb-Omb king or giant Whomp who move around or are harder to —oh she's skipping to Cool Cool Mountain already. The penguin race is really interesting, watch this skip close. It's frame perfect and *really* hard to get."

It *looked* like Catra was just running into a wall and getting a bunch of error sounds. She frowned, tilting her head to listen. "Oof, she's missed that twice now. That's another hard one to get."

"Why does she keep saying no to the penguin race?"

"You'll see."

They watched as she launched herself off the platform for the third time —and the prompt for a race appeared again. "Excellent!" Entrapta said, clapping her hands together. "It's a glitch that takes some time to explain but basically she tricked the penguin into asking her for a race when she was already halfway through. And she wins! Next I think she's going to —yup, hundred stars and eight red coins. They're easy to do together since the eight red coins already boost your coin count. Most non-blindfolded one-twenty runners do it the same way because it just makes sense."

People came and went, attracted by the idea of a blindfolded speedrun and Entrapta's commentary. She had obviously spent a lot of time watching Catra play and getting to know her strats.

"Oh, I guess she decided to do Cool, Cool Mountain all in one go. That's probably easier, especially since the Jolly Roger can be a real time killer."

"That's the underwater one, right?" Adora asked. She knew a bit about the game just from watching Catra play in the past, but it had been awhile.

"One of them, yes. It's *very* sound dependent because it's hard to re-establish yourself when you're underwater, *and* you're losing health

the entire time. And sometimes Catra takes a hit on purpose to glitch through things. All and all, it's a terrible stage."

More people were gathering now. There was commentary on screen as well, interlaced with donation announcements, but the commentator wasn't *nearly* as knowledgeable as Entrapta.

"Oooooh, she's going to Whomp's Fortress next. That one's fascinating. It's a very interesting combination of sound cues and using corners to locate herself. There's some really cool strats, but it can also be a blink and you miss it scenario, so watch closely."

"And she *really* can't see?" someone asked dubiously.

"She's wearing a blindfold and turned away from the screen. Does it *look* like she can see?"

Adora tried to listen to Entrapta, but she was practically enraptured by Catra. She looked so confident. There was a small smile on her lips as she bobbed her head along to the music, sometimes counting shuffles and beats. She was in her element. She was *happy*. None of the drama that had been happening over the last few days mattered. This was what she had been waiting for.

Catra wasn't great at keeping track of time while she was playing, but she was pretty sure she was just over two hours in, and at thirty-one stars. She really needed to blow through Lethal Lava Land and catch up.

It was weird, being alone with her thoughts and the sounds of Mario whooping and yahooing when he jumped. She could hear absolutely nothing outside of her own little world. Lethal Lava Land wasn't *as* bad as Jolly Roger's Bay, because she could use the lava to kind of get around, but she only had so many uses of that. She had the lives to spare, thankfully, but she didn't like wasting if she didn't have to.

Coins, coins, coins. One-hundred coins to keep her health up as she bounced off the lava across the stage. It was, in her opinion, the best run she'd done of that particular one-hundred coin run.

Focus. Keep going. She knew she hadn't given herself any breathing room with the play time, and she was determined to make it. There were no consequences if she went over, of course. But she had pride, and she wouldn't let her ego take a hit *now*.

"She's four hours in and still missing fifteen stars," Bow said with a frown. He and Glimmer had joined Adora, taking up Scorpia's and Entrapta's vacated seats – Entrapta had wandered off, Scorpia hurrying after her, and now Entrapta was doing most of the commentating on Catra's run. No one asked how that had happened.

"*Now she's getting into the really nitpicky parts. Tick Tock Clock is especially important — she* has *to get in with the second hand on twelve to freeze the world because running through here with everything moving would be a disaster*."

Watching Tick Tock Clock was, Adora thought, possibly the most fascinating part. Catra never missed the second hand, managed to freeze the world every time, and somehow got through everything without having to restart.

"*This is usually her best course*," Entrapta admitted about halfway through. "*She can get through it in five to ten minutes not blindfolded*."

"Adora, stop chewing on your thumbnail," Bow said gently, taking Adora's hand from her mouth. "There's nothing to be anxious about."

"I'm just nervous for her. Entrapta said she didn't leave herself any breathing room. She's going to be so disappointed if she doesn't make it."

"But it wont be the end of the world."

"And what a good excuse to give her some good hugs and snuggles," Glimmer added with a sly smile. Adora ignored that, keeping her eyes fixed on the screen.

Rainbow Ride was a little touch and go, and the clock kept going. Adora went back to chewing on her thumbnail, and Bow didnt stop her this time.

Catra went into the final world with one-hundred and nineteen stars, and started searching for red coins. "*This is definitely a dangerous place to look for red coins*," Entrapta said. " *One wrong move and she's over the edge. And remember, even if she gets to one-twenty, it isn't time until she takes Bowser out*."

Most of the other games had wrapped up by this point, and more people were gathering around Catra's screen. Entrapta's commentary was definitely an added bonus.

"*Eighth coin… she has to be* very *careful here, the star appears behind the warp pipe, she has to step very lightly… and she got it!*"

A cheer went up in the room. Adora looked at the timer on the screen. Entrapta had said she still needed to take out Bowser to end the run, and the time was running close.

"*She needs to throw Bowser into the bombs three times, don't forget. It's going to be close*"…

One explosion. Adora accidentally bit her skin, and switched to her other thumb to continue chewing. Two explosions. Catra was already preparing for the final grab when Bowser came back and the stage began to fall apart. She got him, threw him, and…he hit the bomb. Everyone watched, holding their breath, as Bowser hit the ground, spun away into a star, and…

“*Time!*” Entrapta yelled when Catra jumped up to grab the star. Adora looked anxiously at the final time on the screen.

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Catra scrambled to get the blindfold off and whirled to look at the screen for her final time while Entrapta chattered excitedly.

“*New world record* and *one second under estimated time! That’s* incredible*! Perfect final Bowser run all around, way to go Catra!*”

Reactions varied between shocked to *“how the actual fuck?”* to cheering. Adora jumped up without thinking and ran to the gaming area, where Catra was standing and staring incredulously at the screen. She shrieked when Adora grabbed her and swept her up in a hug with such vigor that she spun her.

“Adora!” she yelped, clinging to Adora just in case she dropped her (which would never happen).

“You’re *amazing*,” she said emphatically, still hugging Catra tight. Catra just laughed after a moment, burying her face in Adora’s shoulder. Entrapta’s voice was still running commentary in the background, talking about facts and statistics and the odds and how Catra was the new world record holder for the blindfolded run. The original commentator was trying to get control back to talk about the end of the event and the final amount they had raised. It sounded like it was a lot of money.

Adora didn’t care. She just focused on the feeling of Catra in her arms while the world celebrated around them.

The person in charge eventually got the mic back from Entrapta and announced the after party that would be held in the reception hall. Adora didn’t really want to let go of Catra, so she just kind of shuffle-sidestepped to make the suggestion that they go somewhere else — the after party, one of their rooms, or if they were happy right where they were. That turned out not to be an option, unfortunately.

"Wildcat!" Scorpia cheered as she descended upon them, scooping both women into a tight hug. Entrapta was on her tablet, swiping frantically.

"Someone already updated the leader boards," she reported. "T witter is going *wild*."

"Cool." Catra sounded a little daz ed. Adora gave her another sqeez and reluctantly let her go when Scorpia set them down.

"After party?" Adora suggested. Catra cocked her head, thinking for a moment.

"I dont think I can deal with that crowd," she said slowly . "They could already hear people out in the hall, talking loudly. Her head was spinning. She needed time to sit and process.

"And people are going to want to *talk*," Entrapta said. "This is historic."

Bow and Glimmer poked their heads into the room. "People are asking about the commentator." Bow sounded amused. "Including the people who organiz ed the event."

"I charge per word if they want to hire me," Entrapta said conversationally. Adora couldnt even imagine how much *that* would cost.

Entrapta ended up getting pulled in by people with qestions, and Scorpia helped cover Catra so she could get away without any hassle. Bow and Glimmer gave her qick hugs before disappearing back to the main floor, and Scorpia stayed with Entrapta to make sure she didnt accidentally accept a jb, which left Adora and Catra to themselves.

"My room?" Catra asked. She was the one with an extra door , after all.

"Yeah. Sure."

They walked silently to the elevator, fingers intertwined. Adora's mind was racing with everything she wanted to say, but Catra still looked a bit out of it, and Adora didn't want to overwhelm her.

"Holy shit," she finally breathed, eyes wide. Adora beamed, squeezing her hand.

"You were *incredible*."

Catra looked at her, managing a small smile. "Who let Entrapta do commentary?"

"I don't know if it was a matter of *let*."

They stared at each other for a moment. Then Catra let out a small giggle. Then they started laughing. They felt *good*. Catra collapsed onto the bed, breathless, and Adora sat with her, watching her joyful, carefree expression. This was the Catra she had fallen in love with. The Catra she would always love, even if they could never fix what they'd once had. Maybe they could at least salvage a friendship.

"What are you staring at, doofus?" Oops, Catra had caught her. Adora blew out a long breath, smiling.

"You." No reason to lie. Catra blushed slightly, looking away. Adora flopped down with her, turning on her side to face Catra. "You really are amazing."

Catra scoffed. "All I did was play a video game."

"Not just that. You've had to deal with so much shit because of… well, me—"

Catra sat up slightly. "Adora—"

"No, let me finish. Please?" Catra hesitated, but pressed her lips shut. "You didn't always handle it *well*, but you always found your

way out. You basically rebuilt your life after you left Bright Moon. I cant even imagine what it must have been like to scrub your identity from the Internet and start over completely. But you did it, and then you decided you wanted to try again, and you did, and you rebuilt your channel and your reputation and pulled off this absolutely amazing thing *live*, in front of probably millions of people. And you were trying to deal with your own mental health at the same time. I know how hard it's always been for you to be the spotlight, and how scared you were of being put on the spot in our relationship, and everything that happened was basically a nightmare. But you came back from it all."

I just wish I could have been a part of what you built .

Catra stared at her for a long moment, her expression unreadable. "I've never cared much about YouTube and all that," she said finally. "I mean, it's cool. The followers are mostly cool, and making money playing video games isn't a bad deal. But I just want to enjoy life, you know? The same thing everyone wants."

"*Are* you enjoying it?" Adora asked.

"Sort of. Mostly. Something's missing, though. It's been missing for a long time, but I don't know if I can get it back."

Adora's breath caught. They stared at each other for a long, long moment. "I think you can," she finally said quietly. "Get it back, I mean. If you want."

Catra chewed on the inside of her cheek, eyes filled with cautious hope. "Yeah?"

She *really* hoped she wasn't misreading this. Adora sat up, leaning close to Catra and cupping her cheek. Catra hummed, closing her eyes and leaning into the touch.

"Yeah."

Catra scooted a little closer, curling into Adora's chest. Adora held her tight, daring to kiss the top of her head. Catra hummed again, seeming pleased.

"It'd be long distance again," Catra murmured after a moment.

"I'm sure Glimmer and Bow are preparing to kick me out anyway. They *did* just get engaged and all," Adora joked. And maybe some space would be good. They wouldn't move too fast. Because Adora already wanted to bring Catra home with her, and it was *probably* too soon for that. Maybe.

"They'd dare to break up the Best Friend Squad?" Catra asked with a mock gasp. Actually, that was a good point. How *were* they going to handle that? Adora shook the thought off. It didn't matter right now. She had her entire world in her arms. Life was good.

Peace could never last forever, of course. "*Catra!*" Entrapta burst through the door, exhilarated. "The analytics on your social media are insane." She waved her tablet around. "You have to see it!"

Catra groaned, raising her head to glare blearily at Entrapta. "I do *not* care right now."

Entrapta looked at them for a moment, blinking. "Ah, there's been a reconciliation. We can talk on the way home tomorrow. Have a good night!"

She closed the door without another word. "You found some weird people at Evil University, didn't you?" Adora asked, sounding amused.

"That's putting it nicely." Catra snorted. "They're good friends, though."

"I'm glad you have them." As much as all of this had hurt, Adora was glad Catra hadn't been alone the entire time. She deserved better. She deserved everything.

Adora wanted to give her everything.

Present Day — Monday

Leaving and check-out was a process. Catra *thought* she had gotten off easy by volunteering to pack the car while Scorpia waited in the crowded front lobby, but she hadn't considered one very important thing — Entrapta's final haul.

"Jesus *Christ*, Entrapta."

"I didn't get the forty-nine inch screen!"

Catra sighed, looking away, and saw a certain trio loading up their car. "Hey, I'll be right back."

Entrapta didn't question anything as Catra jogged off. "Hey," she called, shoving her hands in her pockets as she approached. Adora lit up when she saw Catra.

"I was going to try and find you before we left!" she said, bouncing over to hug Catra tight. Catra smiled, returning the hug with the same ferocity.

"Not that I don't want to see you too, but could you actually maybe give me a minute with Sparkles and Arrow Boy?" Adora pulled back to look at Catra, surprised. "Entrapta needs help T etris-ing the car so all three of us can actually get home. I figured I'd ask an expert for help."

It was true, but also an obvious ploy. Still, Adora nodded, heading over to where Entrapta was standing with her pile of equipment.

"What's up?" Bow asked, tilting his head. Catra looked back at them, rocking nervously on her heels.

"I'm sorry." The couple blinked, surprised. "I know I didn't just abandon Adora — I left you guys too. I was scared, and I did a lot of

damage. I never meant for the fallout to be as bad as it was. Iʼm sorry.”

“Aaaaawww .”Bow couldnt help himself. “Y ou like us!”

He swooped in to grab Catra and hug her. “Gah, no, I dont!”Catra protested, kicking her legs half-heartedly. Glimmer watched smugly, arms crossed, smiling, the whole nine yards. “Are you enjoying yourself, Sparkles”?

“Absolutely .”She dropped the act after a moment and moved in to join the hug. “And we forgive you.”

“I take it all back,”Catra grumbled, but she relaxed into the hug, letting the duo have their heartwarming moment. And if she enjoyed it as well..no one had to know .

Adora sighed as she finally got the last piece of eqipment into the car, and looked across the parking lot. She smiled when she Bow and Glimmer hugging Catra. For the first time in five years, it felt like everything had finally back into place. Sure, she and Catra were separating today, but it wouldnt be the end of things.

It was more like a beginning.

One Year Later

Catra wrenched the bedroom door open, yelling, “Can you guys keep it *down*? I can hear you on my recording!”

“W e told you were livestreaming!”Glimmer yelled back. “Might as well come join us!”

“Nope.”Catra closed the door again, but was almost immediately met by a barely audible chorus of “*Catraaaaaaaaa*!”

She sighed, opening the door again, and headed to the living room. Swifty and Sonic were sitting right outside the door, whining. They wanted to get in. Melog was sitting on the stairs, watching them, thoroughly bored.

"Catra!" Adora, Glimmer , and Bow cheered as she tried to work her way into the room without letting the dogs in.

"This is ridiculous," she grumbled, shoving a snout out of the door and closing it. Adora took her hand, dragging her to the couch. "I'm not staying!"

"But you can say hello!" Adora said, kissing her cheek. "We're doing an AMA and people are wondering what we're going to do with an entire house to ourselves."

"Fill it with cats," Catra said, deadpanning. Bow checked the screen.

"That's a *very* approved idea."

"Of course it is. Cats are *always* the right answer on the Internet."

Adora tugged Catra to sit in her lap, hugging her tight. "Well, there goes our AMA," Glimmer said, rolling her eyes. "Everyone's just going to squeal about how *cute* you two are."

"Confirmed," Bow said from the laptop, chuckling. "People are also wondering what's going to happen to the channel with us moving out."

"We're not going that far," Glimmer assured the camera. "Just a condo across town. It might mean less live streams, but we'll still be recording daily episodes."

"Basically , they're not leaving," Catra said. "They're just going to be sleeping in another place."

"And Sonic will be going with us," Bow added. "He'll need to come over a lot to visit his buddy."

"They're not leaving," Catra repeated. "They're never leaving."

"Hey , you signed up for this when you moved in."

Bow looked at the screen again. "Entrapta wants to know if she can have our basement. It's apparently hard to do your analytics when you're in another city ."

"Stop hacking into my channels!"

"It' s not hacking if you never change your passwords."

Catra groaned, covering her face with her hands. "Okay , that's my limit for the day," she said, standing and heading for the door . "Have fun, kids."

"Bye Catra!" the trio said in a chorus. Catra rolled her eyes as she nudged Sonic out of the way and closed the door so the livestream could continue uninterrupted.

She and Adora had agreed to go slow.which was why Catra had waited a whole seven months to relocate to Bright Moon. She still stayed in constant contact with Scorpia, Perfuma, and Entrapta, and tried to go back at least twice a month to visit. But her moving had just made more sense. Besides, it saved the trio from having to try and sell the house. Adora and Catra could afford it on their own. And the recording studio didn't have to be moved.

Catra settled back in her seat and unpaused her game, checking her recording time. Almost an *hour*. It had been mostly consistent gameplay, and who didn't love Kirby? But she was going to have to edit out that pause where she went to yell at the Squad. Ugh.

She finished up the level she was on and paused, ending the recording. She'd do her outro later . She grabbed her phone and pulled up the light app. It had been Bow's idea to install smart bulbs and color code the hallway after she'd been barged in on one time too many while trying to record. She changed the color from red to

normal, then stood, stretching, and opened the door. Melog came wandering up and hopped onto her bed, clearly happy to get away from the dogs. He didn't *hate* them exactly, but there had been some batting and hissing, and Melog definitely didn't want to spend time with them. In theory, he probably shouldn't have been there *at all*, but he had literally tried to pack himself into her boxes. *Everyone* had insisted that Melog needed to go with her or he'd be *miserable*. They were probably right. Catra had spent a few weekends in Bright Moon, and Melog had spent the entire time either outside her door or in the attic apartment if he could get in. The drive from Half Moon to Bright Moon with him in a carrier had been *torture*.

She flopped on the bed with her Switch and started up Splatoon. She had no idea how long the AMA was going to last, but she wasn't going to wait for Bow to be ready to play with her. She jumped into the lounge and waited for a game to start.

Several games and some yelling at useless teammates later, Adora flopped into bed with her, smiling.

"It's so cute when you get mad at people online."

"They're just so useless! Why am I carrying the *entire team*?" Catra hit the power button as her last game ended and rolled over to kiss Adora's cheek. "People suck."

"I know. They're just the worst."

Melog let out an annoyed *mrowl*, jumping onto Adora's side and inserting himself between them. "He realized he wasn't the center of the universe anymore," Adora said with a mock gasp. "The horror..."

"The absolute horror..."

—

Catra still got shitty comments on her videos.

She'd moderated comments for a long time before finally turning it back into a free for all. The first month was a disaster, with the conspiracy theorists *really* breaking out the big guns. Apparently Bow and Glimmer were getting married as a *cover* because Glimmer's homophobic parents wouldn't let her be with Adora. Angella and Micah were *not* homophobic, and laughed when Glimmer told them about that. Bow was just happy that he finally got to have a part in all the weird theories.

Scorpia and Perfuma had taken Catra's worries seriously. Entrapta happily wired up a security system complete with cameras all around the yard. No one ever found Catra or doxxed her, but the women *did* discover a feral cat colony living in their backyard. Scorpia had been delighted and started leaving food out for them immediately.

Some people had gone rabid in the other direction, constantly demanding Catra and Adora content, which was exhausting in its own way. Their long-distance relationship had been the focus of *way* too many fanfics. Entrapta had eventually banned all fanfic websites from their Internet so Catra would stop going back and torturing herself. They'd kept Catra's impending move to Bright Moon *very* quiet, not announcing it until Catra was unpacked and in the house, at which point they had a huge livestream party. It actually wasn't terrible, not that Catra would ever admit that. They might ask her to livestream with them *more*. It was bad enough that Bow managed to drag her in for Splatoon and Smash Brothers. He loved having a Switch buddy.

Luckily, the Internet was always easily distracted by cats. Melog made his Twitter debut, and it broke the entire fanbase for at least a day. Catra saved pics and put them up whenever things started getting too tense. He also featured prominently on the BFS TikTok. Such a hardworking cat.

"So I think I can change Glimbow's entire bedroom into a recording studio," Catra said as she walked around said bedroom. It was currently littered with boxes and probably a safety hazard.

"They're not leaving until next *week*," Adora said from the door, trying and failing to bite down a laugh.

"Yeah, but I have to start planning *now*. I was thinking red and black soundproofing foam – really go for the *edgy* look."

"You are *not* edgy."

Catra gasped, turning to look at her girlfriend in utter betrayal. "How dare you! Take that back."

"You're a marshmallow."

"This is blasphemy. I want a divorce."

"*Why* are you guys in our room?" Glimmer asked, pushing passed Adora and walking in with Bow behind her.

"Planning," Catra said cheerfully. "What do you guys think about black and red soundproofing? Edgy, right?"

"You are the exact *opposite* of edgy," Glimmer said. "Get out of our room."

"Oh! Wait, I have an idea," Bow said excitedly, looking up something on his phone. "Hexagon panels are way cooler, and you could do black and purple for Umbreon and Espeon. It's like your theme!"

Catra glared at him half heartedly. She hated that she liked that idea. "Oooooh, and you could have a shelf in the background with a couple of stuffed Umbreons and Espeons," Adora added, lighting up.

"God knows we have enough of them."

"Um, hello?" Glimmer said, waving her hands. "This is *still* our bedroom! Get out!"

Catra was chuckling as she ducked out of the room, grabbing Adora's hand and pulling her along. They were both laughing by the

time they got to their room.

Life wasn't perfect, but it was *good*. They were happy.

"What are you smiling at?" Catra asked, raising an eyebrow at Adora. She shrugged.

"You. You're cute."

"Nerd."

"*You* are going to have a Pokémon themed recording studio. How am *I* the nerd?"

"You're a sappy nerd. It's different," Catra informed her. Adora rolled her eyes and tugged Catra in to kiss her.

"I love you," Adora whispered against her lips. Catra smiled.

"Love you too, nerd."

It wasn't perfect, but nothing was *perfect*. But it was good. They were happy.

The rest was just extra.

Chapter End Notes

Go give some love to Bubiza, the actual blindfold master, who finished the first 120-run several months ago: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CClvO-FZ

I *love* video games. Idk if that was obvious. I have a dream of getting into streaming/gaming somewhat professionally (especially since it looks like my current full-time job isn't going to exist for much longer lol) but that's probably never going to happen, so for now I live vicariously through fictional characters and continue my writing.

End Notes

Blindfolded Mario 64 speedrun is a real thing, btw. I watched it while I was writing. Several times. It's amazing. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KDwMNik8885s the same speedrunner also completed the 120 blindfolded run recently. I haven't watched it yet because it's eleven hours, but it's on my list. It's so cool what people can do.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!